

Friday, October 2, 2026

mint

Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Why tax refunds matter for Indian apparel exports

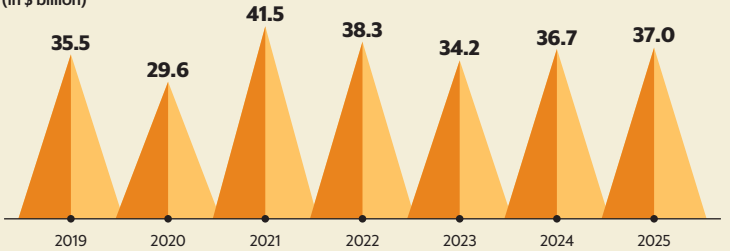
BY DHIRENDRA KUMAR

The Centre has extended the Rebate of State and Central Taxes and Levies (RoSCTL) scheme for apparel and made-up exporters by three months to 31 December, even as it works on a proposal to continue the scheme for another five years, as *Mint* reported on 28 September.

Hard recovery

The recovery of India's textile exports has been uneven since 2020, hinting at competitive pressure from lower-cost manufacturing destinations.

India's export of textiles and apparels (in \$ billion)



Source: DGCIIS

mint

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

1 What is the RoSCTL scheme?

Introduced in March 2019, the RoSCTL refunds eligible state and central taxes, duties and levies embedded in exported apparel and made-ups that are not refunded through other mechanisms. The principle is straightforward: domestic taxes and levies incurred on goods meant for export should not remain embedded in their overseas selling price and make Indian products less competitive. The scheme is therefore different from a direct export subsidy. Its stated purpose is to remit eligible domestic taxes and levies that would otherwise remain embedded in export costs.

MINT

2 Who benefits from the scheme?

The scheme primarily covers exporters of apparel, garments and made-ups, with a significant share of beneficiaries being micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs). According to the textile ministry, more than 15,400 exporters received rebates ranging from 1.7% to 8.2% under the scheme in fiscal year 2025-26 (FY26). Its reach matters because textile and garment manufacturing is spread across multiple clusters. The sector is also labour-intensive, providing direct employment to more than 45 million people, making export competitiveness relevant not only to foreign-exchange earnings but also to jobs.

3 Why is the extension significant?

The government has retained existing rates and guidelines until 31 December, ensuring that the scheme does not lapse while a longer-term decision is worked out. That short horizon is a concern for an industry in which orders are planned months in advance. Industry executives argue that the RoSCTL should have a longer policy horizon.

4 How much does the Centre spend on it?

Government spending stood at ₹9,176 crore in FY22, fell to ₹7,659 crore in FY23, and rose to ₹8,033 crore in FY24, ₹8,565 crore in FY25, and to ₹10,010 crore in FY26. For FY27, the allocation is ₹5,000 crore. The industry argues the scheme is important because Indian exporters should not carry domestic tax costs into overseas markets. With apparel imports from the US and European Union contracting, RoSCTL refunds help them stay competitive, said Prabhu Dhamodharan, convenor, Indian Texpreneurs Federation (ITF).

5 Why does it matter for textile exports?

The government aims to raise textile exports to \$100 billion by 2030. India's apparel exports stood at \$35.49 billion in 2019, fell to \$29.61 billion in 2020, and rebounded to \$41.47 billion in 2021, according to government data. They then fell to \$38.31 billion in 2022 and \$34.23 billion in 2023, before recovering to \$36.71 billion in 2024 and \$36.95 billion in 2025. The uneven recovery points to continued competitive pressure as Indian producers compete with lower-cost manufacturing destinations.

QUICK EDIT

A steeper path ahead

Amid all the flux in the global economy, the finance ministry's economic review for September is reassuring but also sobering. Though it sees India's economy growing 7.3% in the July-September quarter, an enviably high rate, the momentum may be slowing. Domestic and external challenges abound, making it harder to hold that pace. The impact of weak monsoon rains on farm output, high oil import bills, inflation trends and globally hardening interest rates could all weigh on the economy. "India cannot afford to take its growth performance for granted," it said. Weaponization of supply chains and geopolitical polarization are intensifying in its analysis. Overall, its assessment has a cautious tone, which should keep policymakers on their toes. Monthly indicators of economic activity, thankfully, have held up well. September's purchasing managers' index reading for manufacturing was at 55.1, up from 52.8 in August, and the month's gross GST revenue mop-up of ₹2.04 trillion was 15% over last year's level. India's stock market, though, seems to have turned into a one-way street lately. It has been reacting disproportionately to bad news. When that might change is hard to bet on.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

When AI can process thousands of documents within moments, and when governments have access to real-time data, citizens expect quick solutions.

NARENDRA MODI
PRIME MINISTER

He was addressing the centenary celebrations of the Union Public Service Commission.



INSIDE

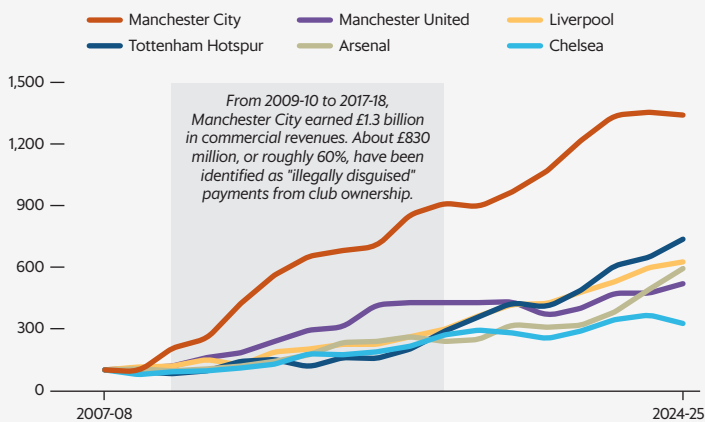
- Mark to Market | Manufacturing PMI's dead cat bounce >P4
- Global | U.S. pressure campaign leaves Iranian tankers stranded in Asian waters >P8
- Money | Tech wealth fuelled Bengaluru's luxury home boom. What now? >P11
- Views | Why Gandhi's talisman should remain resonant >P12
- Business of Life | Destinations that offer luxury on a platter >P14

mint | DATA BITES

HOW DID MANCHESTER CITY'S REVENUES GROW?

Manchester City has been found guilty of "inflating" commercial revenues by an independent commission. Data shows after Abu Dhabi United Group bought the club in 2008, its financial and sporting fortunes skyrocketed over the next decade.

Relative movement in annual commercial revenues of big six football Premier League clubs (rebased, 2007-08=100)



Data: Anjishnu Das
Graphic: Prateek Kumar

Source: Deloitte Sports Business Group, annual club statements

m COLUMNS

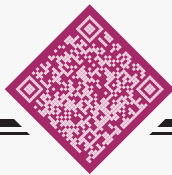


INDIRA RAJARAMAN
THE LINDSEY GRAHAM
SANCTIONING RUSSIA AND
IRAN ACT IS A TRAVESTY >P13

Himanshu
EL NIÑO HAS
SPELT A TWIN
WHAMMY FOR THE
COUNTRY'S RURAL
ECONOMY >P12

Ajit
Ranade
HOW THE TATA
LEGACY EVOKES
GANDHI'S IDEA OF
TRUSTEESHIP >P12





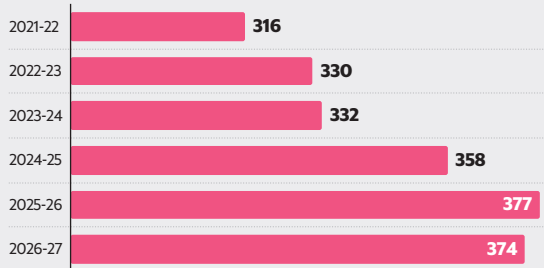
DATA RECAP THE WEEK IN CHARTS

CURATED BY HOWINDIALIVES.COM | feedback@livemint.com

From the government setting a lower foodgrain production target for the ongoing crop year to deficient monsoon rainfall in two of every five districts in India, the weakness in the Indian stock market weighing on valuations across the board, Tamil Nadu being the sole leading state to increase its share of national factory output in 2024-25 and the continuing medal run of Indian chess—here is this week’s news in numbers.

FOOD SHOCK

India's foodgrain production (in million tonnes)



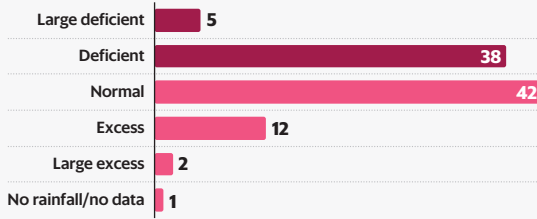
Data for 2025-26 are third advance estimates; 2026-27 figures are projections. Source: Unified Portal for Agricultural Statistics; Media reports

THE GOVERNMENT has set a foodgrain production target of 373.93 million tonnes (mt) for the 2026-27 crop year, about 0.7% below the record output estimated for 2025-26. The lower target comes amid deficient monsoon rainfall during the kharif season and the threat of El Niño. Foodgrain output rose 7.7% in 2025-26 and 5.3% in 2024-25.

The lower target reflects subdued expectations for rice and maize output. Agriculture minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said crops had been damaged across about 611,000 hectares in Karnataka, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, Rajasthan and Gujarat because of heavy rains, floods or droughts.

DEFICIENT RAINS

Share of India's districts by deviation from LPA (in %), during southwest monsoon, Jun-Sep 2026



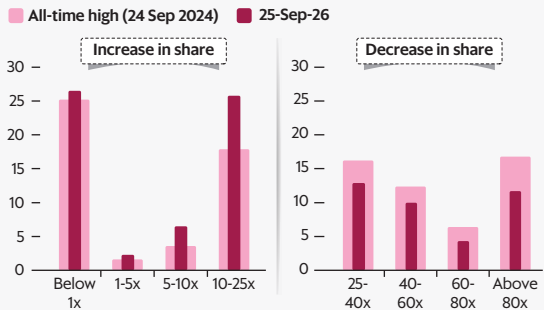
LPA: long-period average (1971 to 2020). Rainfall categories are based on deviation from normal: large excess >60%; excess 20% to 59%; normal -19% to +19%; deficient -20% to -59%; and large deficient -60% to -100%.

Source: India Meteorological Department

INDIA'S SOUTH-WEST monsoon ended at 87% of its long-period average (LPA), making it the 13th-weakest since 1901, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD) data. The June-September monsoon began with rainfall 35.4% below normal in June, followed by a 1% surplus in July, a 16.3% shortfall in August and a 7.6% shortfall in September. India last recorded a below-normal monsoon in 2023, when rainfall was 95% of the LPA. The deficit was spread across the country, with 43% of India's 734 districts recording deficient rainfall. Among major agricultural states, Bihar, Punjab and Karnataka each recorded deficient rainfall in four of five districts.

SILVER LININGS

Share of BSE companies (in %) by price-to-earnings ratio range



Source: ACE Equity; Mint analysis

THE INDIAN stock market continued to weaken, with the benchmark BSE Sensex losing 2.7% during the trading week. The index is now down 16.5% from its all-time high. The correction has, however, pushed a larger share of stocks into lower valuation bands, as measured by their price-to-earnings (PE) multiples, according to a *Mint* analysis of 3,756 BSE-listed companies based on ACE Equity data.

The share of stocks trading at a PE multiple above 40 fell from 36% in September 2024 to 26%, while the share in the 10-25 PE band rose from 18% to 26%. While lower PE multiples can signal attractive valuations, they can also point to weaker earnings growth.

NUMBERS TALK

● **1%:** The increase in the minimum support price of wheat for the upcoming *rabi* marketing season. The highest increases were for safflower, at 10.3% and rapeseed and mustard, at 6.7% each.

● **103,000:** Houses sold across nine major cities in the July-September quarter, down 6% from a year ago, according to PropEquity. Only Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Navi Mumbai recorded growth.

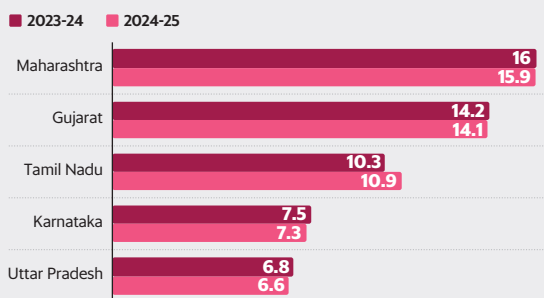
● **16:** Indian men who joined the boards of S&P 500 companies this year, according to ISS-Corporate and data provider Equilar. Only white men and women secured a higher number of board seats.

● **\$6 trillion:** Annual global revenue the artificial intelligence (AI) market will need to generate by 2031 to justify the capital being deployed to build AI infrastructure, according to Bain & Co.

● **₹645 crore:** What ITC paid to raise its stake in Sproutlife Foods, which owns nutrition and healthy foods brand Yoga Bar, from 47.5% to 100%. ITC first invested in Sproutlife in May 2023.

MANUFACTURING STATE

Top five states by share of manufacturing GVA (in %)



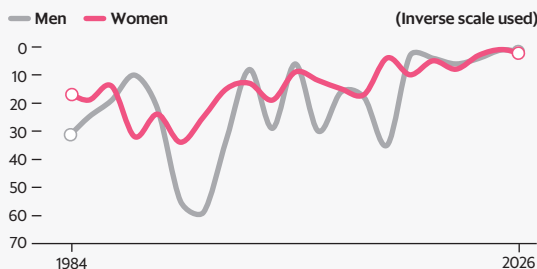
Source: Annual Survey of Industries

THE NUMBER of registered factories in operation in India increased 2.6% year-on-year in 2024-25, while employment in them rose 7.3% to 16.6 million, according to the Annual Survey of Industries (ASI) 2024-25, released by the statistics ministry.

Tamil Nadu accounted for the largest share of manufacturing employment at 15%, followed by Maharashtra at 13.1%, Gujarat at 13%, Uttar Pradesh at 8.7% and Haryana at 6.4%. Gross value added (GVA) by factories increased 9.6%. Among the five states with the largest GVA, four saw their share of national factory GVA decline. Tamil Nadu was the exception: its share rose from 10.3% in 2023-24 to 10.9% in 2024-25.

MEDAL RUN

India's rank in Chess Olympiad over the years



Data since 1984, when Viswanathan Anand made his debut at the Chess Olympiad.

Source: olimpbase.org

INDIA'S MEN'S and women's chess teams finished among the medals at the recently concluded Chess Olympiad in Samarkand, Uzbekistan, but could not defend their titles. The men finished second and the women third, with Uzbekistan A winning the men's competition and China the women's.

India also won the title of best overall side and individual medals for six of its 10 players, including a gold for Savitha Shri. It was the sixth consecutive time that the Indian men finished in the Olympiad's top 10, while the women extended their top-10 run to five.

www.howindialives.com is a database and search engine for public data

MINT BEST OF THE WEEK

TVS ties deepen



A company owned by N. Chandrasekaran's family is pursuing a ₹330-crore industrial park in Karnataka for TVS Motor. The ties have raised questions over disclosure and potential conflicts, especially after TVS chairman-emeritus Venu Srinivasan backed Chandrasekaran's third term.



Air India's double act



Tejendra Gebremariam has inherited an airline group bleeding cash, with Air India and Air India Express losing ₹22,238 crore in FY26. AIX is growing rapidly but remains financially stretched, even as Tata shifts more routes and aircraft its way. Can Gebremariam make the two-airline model work?



Why the Mistrys want out



The SP Group's ₹25,000-crore offer to sell part of its Tata Sons stake fell flat, with the board backing the extension for N. Chandrasekaran and moving towards a listing. For the Mistrys, a heavily leveraged group and a prized but illiquid stake have made Tata Sons' future valuation more urgent.



Friday, October 2, 2026

mint

livemint.com

T20: when club or country turns into a googly

P10

Anup Bagchi named HDFC Bank chief for three years

P5

SENSEX 71,909.69 ↓ 570.59

NIFTY 22,421.95 ↓ 198.50

DOLLAR ₹96.32 ↓ ₹0.49

EURO ₹108.53 ↑ ₹0.31

OIL \$99.74 ↑ \$2.08

POUND ₹127.13 ↑ ₹0.12

Healthy realty units may gain IBC shield

IBBI set to tweak rules to allow CoC shield solvent projects

Banikinkar Pattanayak
banikinkar.pattanayak@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Homebuyers in healthy real estate projects may soon be spared the fallout when their developer defaults on another project. The insolvency watchdog is set to tweak regulations to allow the committee of creditors (CoC) to recommend keeping solvent projects out of bankruptcy proceedings, even when the developer as a whole enters the Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP), two people in the know said.

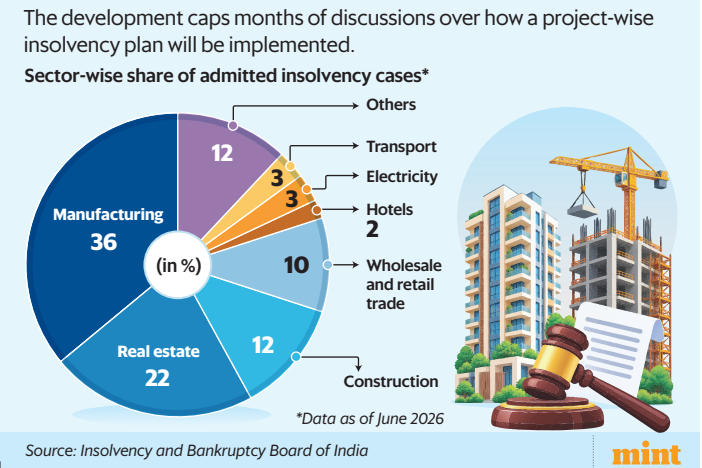
The proposal, however, must be backed by a 66% vote of the CoC and approved by the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) for it to take effect, the people told *Mint*.

The Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (IBBI), which regulates the regime under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), had deliberated on the proposal at its last board meeting held late August, and the new regulations would be notified shortly, they said.

The development caps months of discussions over how a project-wise insolvency plan will be implemented.

Currently, once a builder is

HOME GUARD



REAL TEST

MOVE needs 66% CoC approval and NCLT clearance

IBBI had deliberated on the proposal at its board meet in August

IBBI yet to count projects, homebuyers likely to benefit

admitted into the CIRP, all its projects come under insolvency proceedings. This hurts the interests of buyers living in finished or solvent projects, who then face disruption in maintenance and uncertainties in registration because the same developer defaulted elsewhere.

The development assumes sig-

nificance given that real estate accounts for 22% of insolvency cases undergoing resolution in India, and is the second-biggest sector after manufacturing, which makes up for 36%.

Several real estate firms—such as

TURN TO PAGE 6

UPI transaction volumes, value fall after MDR news

Anshika Kayastha
anshika.kayastha@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Transactions on the unified payments interface (UPI) platform dipped in September after the government announced reintroduction of a merchant discount rate (MDR) on select transactions from 15 October, with a sharper decline in the second half pointing to some caution among customers and merchants ahead of the new fee.

The UPI platform processed 24.07 billion transactions in September, down 1.8% from August. The value of transactions fell 1.5% to ₹29.4 lakh crore, according to data from the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), which operates the UPI platform.

Importantly, NPCI's daily data shows a dip in both volumes and value in month's second half, after the 15 September MDR announcement.

Daily transaction volumes ranged between 792 million and 859 million in the first half of September, before falling to between 748 million and 810 million in the second. The value of transactions declined to between ₹73.615 crore and ₹99.645 crore, from ₹79,166



UPI processed 24.07 billion transactions in September.

crore to ₹1.3 trillion in the first half, with the last day of the month as an outlier with transactions of ₹1.1 trillion.

Some of this decline reflects normal seasonal patterns rather than MDR-driven caution: UPI transactions typically slow in a month's latter half, and volumes and values also tend to run lower in 30-day months compared with 31-day months. A decline beyond these historical patterns, however, could signal greater caution among users.

TURN TO PAGE 9

Centre builds guardrails before UPI fee debut >P2

JSW beats Tata, Leyland to win 1,200 e-bus tender

Ayaan Kartik & Manas Pimpalkhare

NEW DELHI

Sajjan Jindal-owned JSW Group has raced ahead of established players Tata Motors and Ashok Leyland to win its first government order for electric buses, emerging as the lowest bidder for about 1,200 units in a 4,054-bus tender, according to two executives in the know.

The order, under the PM-eBus Sewa scheme, gives JSW a sizeable foothold in a market dominated by legacy bus makers and newer players such as Eka Mobility and PMI Electro Mobility.

The order win will boost the Jindal conglomerate's aggressive automobile push. The group had, in 2024, set up its commercial-vehicle entity, JSW Greentech, a subsidiary of Sajjan Jindal family-owned JSW Green Mobility.

While the tender value is not known, electric buses in such tenders are typically priced about ₹1-1.25 crore each. Operators generally procure these from manufacturers and run them for state transport units that pay on a

TURN TO PAGE 9

DON'T MISS



India can't rest on growth laurels: finance ministry

India's resilience to external shocks is being tested by a tougher global fight for capital, with unsettled trade ties with the US, AI boom and a manufacturing push in developed economies all threatening to weigh on inflows, the finance ministry said. >P2

GST mop-up stays above ₹2 trillion for third month

India's gross goods and services tax (GST) collections rose 14.7% in September to ₹2.04 trillion from ₹1.77 trillion a year earlier, with the headline growth driven largely by a sharper rise in tax collected on imports, which increased nearly 26%. >P2

New advisory firms target startups, private equity funds

A fresh crop of advisory firms has sprung up in India amid intensifying competition in the sector and the changing nature of work in consultancy services. These mid-tier consulting companies have chalked out a different strategy. >P3

Accenture sees higher AI spend by clients as token costs fall

Accenture Plc expects companies to spend more on automation tools as the costs of deploying them reduce, even as it expects revenue deflation to persist for technology services firms. The management's upbeat tone was backed by its results. >P6

Canara Bank

A Government of India Undertaking

Together We Can

Thank You

Our Customers for your continued trust and support

Our Stakeholders for your guidance and partnership

Our Employees for your dedication and commitment

₹30 LAKH CRORE+

TOTAL GLOBAL BUSINESS

(Provisional Figures as on 30-09-2026)

We express our profound gratitude to our esteemed customers, stakeholders and well-wishers for their valuable support.

1 Bank Number 1800 1030 24x7 www.canarabank.bank.in



Centre has halved permissible stock to 1,000 quintals, holding period to 15 days.

REUTERS

Govt cuts sugar stock limit to curb hoarding for festivals

Dhirendra Kumar
dhirendra.kumar@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

The government has tightened sugar stockholding norms for dealers ahead of the festive season, halving the permissible stock to 1,000 quintals and the holding period to 15 days, in a bid to curb hoarding and ensure adequate supplies to consumers during the peak festive season beginning 11 October.

The revised norms will take effect from 15 October and stay in force till 30 November, the ministry of consumer affairs, food and public distribution said in a statement on Thursday. Dealers will not be allowed to hold sugar for more than 15 days from the date of receipt or hold more than 1,000 quintals of stock at any location at any given time, it said. The move aims to keep sugar prices in check at a time when demand typically rises during festival season.

Retail sugar prices stood at ₹55.62 per kg on 1 October, about 20% higher than a year earlier. However, prices have corrected sharply from their August peak, falling 11.7% from ₹62.96 per kg a month earlier.

However, a higher stockholding limit of 2,000 quintals has been allowed in Kolkata and its extended metropolitan areas and Assam, taking into account the logistical requirements of supplying sugar to eastern and north-eastern India and the seasonal surge in demand during Durga Puja.

"Kolkata sources sugar from Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra and Karnataka and supplies it to the eastern part of the country, including the North-Eastern region," the ministry said, explaining the higher limit for the region. The additional allowance for Assam takes into account geographical constraints and transportation logistics. The move comes at the beginning of the new sugar season on 1 October, with the government seeking to prevent the accumulation of stocks in the distribution chain and discourage speculative trading amid peaking demand.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

India cannot rest on growth laurels: finance ministry

India faces a stiff challenge in drawing GDP capital flows amid external turmoil, says economic review

Banikankar Pattanayak
banikankar.pattanayak@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India's resilience to external shocks is being tested by a tougher global fight for capital, with unsettled trade ties with the US, the investment boom around artificial intelligence (AI) and a manufacturing push in developed economies all threatening to weigh on inflows, the finance ministry said on Thursday.

The country faces a "stiff challenge" in drawing capital flows amid external turmoil, like other developing economies, while short-term pressure on the rupee remains. The economy has shown it can absorb shocks, the ministry said, but the country cannot afford to lower its guard or rest on its post-pandemic growth laurels.

Economic growth, therefore, has to be "earned every quarter", the ministry said in its economic review for September, highlighting the challenge for policymakers.

India has remained the world's fastest-growing major economy since fiscal year 2022 (FY22), and most analysts expect it to expand 6.8-7% this fiscal year after a stronger-than-expected 7.8% growth in the June quarter.

The June quarter's growth momentum has extended into the second quarter of FY27, "though at a more measured pace".



Economic growth has to be 'earned every quarter', the finance ministry said in its economic review for September.

MINT

"Our nowcasting measure, unveiled in the Economic Survey earlier this year, anticipates a real GDP growth rate of 7.3% in the fiscal second quarter," the ministry said.

The ministry expects net foreign direct investment (FDI) inflows to rebound this fiscal year through March 2027, while stressing the economy's resilience to external shocks. Between April and July, net FDI rose 38% from a year earlier to \$13.4 billion, while gross inflows stood at \$43.9 billion.

The report pointed to a global headwinds. Oil prices surged in September following a fresh flare-up in the West

Asia conflict, while global bond yields have also risen.

India's bond yield has risen at a much slower pace, the ministry said, but the resulting lower risk premium is putting pressure on the rupee. Still, "there is every possibility that, over the medium term, investors would appreciate the fundamental reasons behind the lower risk premium on Indian debt".

The yield on the 10-year US treasury papers has jumped 52 basis points in the past one month to 5.32%, while that on the Indian government securities of the same tenor has risen 25 bps to 7.21%.

The ministry identified three short-term pressures on India's ability to attract capital.

First, trade relations with the US remain unsettled after Washington adopted a law in late September empowering the President to impose tariffs of up to 100% on countries buying Russian crude oil.

Second, the global AI investment cycle continues to channel capital across borders. "At the same time, the AI bubble has not begun its inevitable meaningful deflation. The AI story continues to drive capital investment and capital flows across borders," the report said. Third, developed economies are competing to secure investments for renewed manufacturing ambitions amid the increasing weaponization of global supply chains.

The ministry pointed to several signs that domestic growth remains resilient. Merchandise and services exports may reach a record \$1 trillion this fiscal year, as they have already crossed \$400 billion in the first five months of FY27.

"That is a very strong confirmation that India's trade agreements are providing impetus to India's exports. It can only get better from here, with more trade agreements on the anvil," it said. The trade deficit narrowed in August, helped by a 26.1% jump in goods exports.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

GST mop-up stays above ₹2 trillion for third month

Dhirendra Kumar
dhirendra.kumar@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India's gross goods and services tax (GST) collections rose 14.7% in September to ₹2.04 trillion from ₹1.77 trillion a year earlier, with the headline growth driven largely by a sharper rise in tax collected on imports, which increased nearly 26%, according to provisional data released by the finance ministry on Thursday.

September was the third month this fiscal year in which collections crossed the ₹2 trillion mark, but were below the ₹2.11 trillion collected in July, when the monthly mop-up crossed ₹2 trillion for the second time. July's collection was the second-highest since GST was introduced in July 2017, after the record ₹2.43 trillion collected in April 2026.

The September numbers come ahead of the 57th GST Council meeting on 7 October in New Delhi. While the council's agenda has not yet been made public, discussions are likely to include a review of GST on merchant discount rate (MDR) on UPI transactions, with a new MDR levy slated to take effect from 15 October. The meeting could also provide an opportunity to review the implementation of rate rationalization and take up outstanding issues under the indirect tax regime, *Mint* reported on 28 August.



Gross GST collections were ₹1.77 trillion a year ago.

MINT

Gross domestic GST revenue rose 10.1% to ₹1.38 trillion in September from ₹1.25 trillion a year earlier.

GST collected on imports jumped 25.9% to ₹65,525 crore. The rise is in line with the trend seen earlier in the fiscal.

According to a Crisil Ratings analysis published on 22 September, IGST collections from imports grew nearly 30% in the five months through August, aided by imports of electronics, machinery, gold, fertilisers and other key goods. Crisil also said elevated commodity prices, rupee depreciation and stable import volumes were supporting import-linked IGST collections.

In September, domestic GST revenue increased by ₹12,662 crore over the year, while GST revenue from imports rose by ₹13,494 crore.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

CAFE-III offers 3-year cushion to self-attest fuel efficiency tech

Manas Pimpalkhare & Ayaan Kartik

NEW DELHI

India's carmakers will get three years to self-certify a dozen fuel-saving technologies under the Corporate Average Fuel Efficiency (CAFE) III rules, which will kick in on 1 April, helping them meet the tighter efficiency targets. During this period, the ministry of road transport and highways (MoRTH) will develop certification methods for these technologies, which will become mandatory from FY31.

CAFE-III rules were notified amid a deep divide in the world's third largest automobile market by sales volume, as a September 2025 draft of these norms had created a special carve-out for cars weighing under 909kg, which was widely seen benefiting market leader Maruti Suzuki India Ltd. The issue is now resolved as the overall targets for light cars have been eased in the final norms.

After one year of consulta-



Carmakers can self-certify a dozen fuel-saving technologies.

MINT

tions, the final norms were notified by the ministry of power on Wednesday, setting a 16% fuel efficiency improvement target for India's carmakers over the next five years.

As per the rules, MoRTH will develop the certification requirements during the first three-year CAFE-III block, during which carmakers will self-certify these products and claim a 9g CO₂/km incentive every year, equal to a fuel efficiency relaxation equalling 0.3795 litres/100km benefit

on the target every year.

Fuel efficiency targets are set for the average fuel efficiency of a carmaker's annual sales. They are measured in terms of litres of fuel consumed for covering 100km. The math for how much fuel a vehicle consumes begins with its tailpipe emissions (grams of carbon dioxide emitted per km), that's converted into fuel used per 100km.

Carmakers need to ensure their fleets have an average efficiency of 3.9960 litres/100km in FY28, followed by 3.8600 litres in FY29, 3.7585 in FY30, 3.5313 in FY31 and 3.3273 in FY32. They will have to comply with requirements that MoRTH will create for these 12 technologies in the second block, covering FY31 and FY32.

Queries emailed to BEE, the ministries of road transport, power, and heavy industries, and carmakers Maruti Suzuki, Tata Motors, Hyundai, and M&M remained unanswered.

manas.pimpalkhare@livemint.com
For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Centre fixes guardrails ahead of UPI fee

Dhirendra Kumar
dhirendra.kumar@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

As India's new fee on UPI merchant transactions kicks in on 15 October, the government is preparing to ensure the cost does not unfairly land on consumers. The department of consumer affairs is strengthening the National Consumer Helpline (NCH) to handle complaints under the new merchant discount rate (MDR) framework and clarify which UPI payments must remain free, two government officials said.

The department, the custodian of consumer rights, will support the finance ministry in resolving complaints and grievances received through the consumer helpline, they said. The department has strengthened the helpline to handle such complaints, having already managed a similar flow post rationalization of goods and services tax rates last September.

"Since the NCH serves as a pre-litigation consumer grievance redressal mechanism, the department is putting in place a detailed set of dos and don'ts to guide consumers on the



The department of consumer affairs is strengthening the National Consumer Helpline to handle MDR-related complaints.

ISTOCKPHOTO

new framework," said the first of the two people cited above. "It is also training call-centre executives to respond to consumer queries and grievances with accurate and relevant information."

"As clearly stated by the finance ministry, person-to-person (P2P) UPI transactions will remain completely free, while a 0.4% MDR will apply only to specified person-to-merchant (P2M) transactions of above

₹2,000. Transactions of up to ₹2,000 will also remain free," said the second person.

"If consumers register complaints with the NCH against merchants for imposing charges in violation of these provisions, the complaints will be examined under the Consumer Protection Act and necessary action will be taken," the person said.

To be sure, for P2M UPI transactions of ₹75,000 and

The consumer affairs dept will support the finance ministry in resolving grievances received on NCH

above, the MDR is capped at ₹300 per transaction. The standard MDR is 0.4%, but the cap means the charge does not keep increasing beyond ₹300.

The helpline is a channel for consumers to seek clarifications and redressal. After the GST rationalization move, it got 3,981 queries and grievances in about two weeks of implementation. Of these, 69% were grievances, while 31% were queries.

Queries will be answered immediately, while for grievances, the consumer affairs department will examine whether they can be addressed under the Consumer Protection Act.

Complaints that fall under the purview of the finance ministry will be forwarded to the concerned department for appropriate action, the officials said.

Queries sent to the spokespersons of the consumer affairs department, the finance ministry and the department of financial services secretary remained unanswered until press time.

manas.pimpalkhare@livemint.com

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

MINT SHORTS

Power demand dips, pushes exchange prices to near zero

New Delhi: Heavy rains and a late-month dip in demand pushed power prices on exchanges to near-zero in several trading blocks (of 15 minutes each) in the last week of September, Indian Energy Exchange data shows. On 26 and 27 September, prices on the real-time platform were at or below 10 paise a unit for 26 and 18 trading blocks, respectively.



RITURAJ BARUAH

FSSAI suspends licences of Shivam Agro, TCF Chocolates

New Delhi: The Food Safety and Standards Authority

of India (FSSAI) has suspended licences of Shivam Agro and TCF Chocolates & Gifts Pvt. Ltd. "following serious food safety violations identified during inspection". The action reinforces the importance of food safety, hygiene and regulatory compliance, the regulator said in a social media post. The companies were directed to cease all food business activities during the suspension period.

Oil refiners change tactics and hire ships to cross Hormuz

Indian oil refiners are hiring tankers to sail through the Strait of Hormuz to pick up crude from within the Persian Gulf, a change of tactics to help them cut costs and secure their supply chains. Processors have issued tenders and are negotiating with shipping lines, people familiar with the efforts said. Indian refiners have avoided sending their own tankers through Hormuz since early in the US-Iran war owing to the risk of attacks.



BLOOMBERG

Goyal, Greer hold talks on India-US interim trade deal



Milwaukee: Commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said on Thursday that he met United States trade representative Jamieson Greer and discussed steps for early conclusion of the India-US bilateral trade agreement. Goyal met Greer on the sidelines of the G20 Trade Ministers' meeting, and was also to meet Canada's trade minister for non-US trade, Maninder Sidhu.

India steps up palm oil buying as tax cut spurs restocking

India is snapping up palm oil after New Delhi slashed import duties, prompting refiners to replenish depleted inventories ahead of the festival season. The buying spree could provide a fresh boost to the global palm market as supplies at top producers Indonesia and Malaysia remain ample.



BLOOMBERG

RBI forex swaps lets firms tap dollar funding at lower cost

Mumbai: Billions of dollars of forex swaps by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) have shifted the economics of cross-currency funding for Indian firms, creating an opportunity to access dollar funding at a relatively lower cost. RBI has been draining surplus liquidity in the banking system through dollar-rupee swaps.

CORRECTIONS AND CLARIFICATIONS

Mint welcomes comments, suggestions or complaints about errors.

Readers can alert the newsroom to any errors in the paper by emailing us, with your full name and address to feedback@livemint.com.

It is our policy to promptly respond to all complaints. Readers dissatisfied with the response or concerned about Mint's journalistic integrity may write directly to the editor by sending an email to asktheditor@livemint.com

Mint's journalistic Code of Conduct that governs our newsroom is available at www.livemint.com



New advisory firms target startups, private equity funds

The founders of these new firms cut their teeth in established audit and advisory firms

Devina Sengupta
devina.sengupta@livemint.com
MUMBAI

A fresh crop of advisory firms has sprung up in India amid intensifying competition in the sector and the changing nature of work in consultancy services.

Squeezed between the established Big Four and management strategy consulting companies, these mid-tier consulting companies have chalked out a different strategy—offering specialized services to startups and private equity and venture capital firms that are more likely to tap the new cohort.

The founders of this new set of consulting companies cut their teeth in the established audit and advisory firms, but unlike their larger competitors, they are focussed on offering a select bouquet of services such as managing family offices, risk advisory, and planning initial public offerings (IPOs) instead of providing the gamut of services from IT to audits and consulting.

"The consulting sector grows at almost twice the rate at which GDP of a country does and therefore there is a lot of work coming in for the newer players as well," said Jamil Khatri, co-founder and chief of Unicus Consultech.

Khatri led the assurance practice of KPMG and quit to start Unicus in 2022. He said Unicus differentiates itself by specializing in IPO-readiness, finance transformation, artificial intelligence and risk.

"While legacy companies may have some bias for larger brands, startups, PE and VC firms are keen to work with newer consulting companies like us. We are 800 employees with 80 partners, many of whom are from the Big Four," Khatri said.

In audit and advisory parlance, the Big Four are EY, KPMG, Deloitte and PwC, firms that were predominantly



Competition in the consulting sector is getting stiffer.

ISTOCKPHOTO

audit companies but expanded over the years into advisory services. Armed with thousands of partners, these giants together employ 2,00,000 people. They often move into the lanes of management consulting companies such as Kearney, Bain & Co, McKinsey

their own portfolios, the opportunity of acquiring equity in the new company and more independence. The calling card of the new ventures includes a more agile workplace where there is little hierarchy and decision-making lies largely in the hands of the partners.

MARKET SHIFT

THE consulting sector grows at almost twice the rate at which GDP of a country does

IN audit and advisory parlance, the Big Four are EY, KPMG, Deloitte and PwC

GLOBAL wars, digitalization, tariffs and AI are reshaping advisory firms' offerings

WHILE boutique consulting firms are getting aggressive, established ones are making adjustments

& Co., and Boston Consulting Group, which do not work on audits and focus on strategic consulting. This cohort runs smaller teams of a few hundred only. According to executives, the newer crop of consulting companies picks up partners from larger firms, luring them with prospects of building

"We manage to hire without a significant raise but what we offer additionally is equity, which can remain invested in the company even when the partner leaves," Khatri said.

A senior headhunter at one of India's top three search firms said the demand for consultants is on the rise as clients

want specialized services which some of the advisory firms offer.

For the newer lot, the role of consultants has changed in many ways since the pandemic. Global wars, businesses going digital, a hazy vision of business cycles given the tariff wars and geopolitical strains along with the impact of artificial intelligence have led advisory firms to rejig their offerings to clients.

"Clients want clear, focused advice—with their needs at the centre. At Transaction Square, we partner with them to execute complex decisions across restructuring, family offices and M&A," said Girish Vanvari, founder of Transaction Square.

Vanvari was national leader for tax at KPMG before he started his company in 2018. Of the other founders, Amol Khanna and Chirag Shah came from KPMG while Saloni Khandelwal was from PwC. Some clients may need specialists instead of a large brand that bills higher and this is where boutique consulting firms come into play.

"Our SAP practice has nearly doubled in recent years, making it a key growth area for us, alongside technology transformation, cyber security and privacy," said Sachin Tayal, managing director, Protiviti Member Firm for India, referring to support services for the enterprise software.

While boutique consulting firms are getting aggressive, the established ones are going through their own adjustments. PwC India struck a joint venture with PwC US Advisory, prompting rivals to reassess ties with their own offshore units. Competition in the consulting sector is getting stiffer as more entities start testing the waters.

Mint reported in September that Temasek-backed upGrad is entering B2B advisory services as it broadens its portfolio ahead of a planned 2027 listing.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#)

Google's Gemini 4 faces doubts over coding skills

Bloomberg
[feedback@livemint.com](#)

Alphabet Inc.'s Google has begun rolling out Gemini 4 Argon, its long-awaited flagship artificial intelligence model, but the company is grappling with internal scepticism over how well it performs in key areas, such as coding.

Google unveiled the model Wednesday to a small group of trusted cybersecurity partners and said it will expand access after additional testing, starting with paid subscribers. The company said Gemini 4 posted leading scores on several benchmark tests, including beating OpenAI's Astra model on one that measures security skills.

But some insiders say those metrics don't tell the whole story. While Gemini 4 has performed well on benchmarks widely used to gauge model efficacy, it does less well when employees actually put it to work, according to people with direct access to the effort. The model struggles to handle

Google unveiled the model on Wednesday to a small group of trusted cybersecurity partners

Alphabet shares rose about 1.7% in extended trading after the company's announcement. Late in regular trading, they pared Wednesday's earlier gains after Bloomberg reported employee scepticism about the model.

Google has laboured recently to develop models that can compete with OpenAI and Anthropic PBC. The company had planned to release a different version in June, dubbed Gemini 3.5 Pro, but abandoned the effort, the peo-



Some employees believe Anthropic's Fable and OpenAI's Astra models are improving at a faster rate than Gemini. AFP

ple said.

Google said it would be inaccurate to say that Gemini 4 is underperforming in areas such as coding. The company referred *Bloomberg* back to comments made last week by Koray Kavukcuoglu, the head of Google DeepMind who said he was encouraged by the model's performance.

"I have the utmost trust in the team," Kavukcuoglu said at a conference hosted by tech news site The Information. "In my mind, it's a certainty that

we are always gonna be at the frontier."

There is a spectrum of opinion inside Google. Some employees believe Anthropic's Fable and OpenAI's Astra models are

improving at a faster rate than Gemini. These people believe that Gemini 4—even at its best—will still lag behind those models in some areas. Other employees believe the coming version has caught up with the leading AI labs.

A Google employee familiar with model development said there is "large consensus" internally at the company that Gemini 4 is at the frontier. This person said the company had

conducted rigorous tests of the models and denied that they struggle with messy, real-world coding tasks.

Google badly needs Gemini 4 to succeed. Versions of the model underpin nearly every product the company sells, from the AI answers atop Search, Google's main profit engine, to Maps, Gmail and Chrome. Each of those products has more than a billion users, a distribution advantage some of the company's rivals lack.

But OpenAI and Anthropic are increasingly moving beyond selling models to building products of their own, including coding agents. Failing to deliver a cutting-edge model could give Google's competitors more time to convince consumers, developers and businesses that the future of search and software should run on their platforms instead.

In response to questions from *Bloomberg*, Google said that even though its last Pro model was released in February, the company has since seen growth in its AI products, including the enterprise version of Gemini as well as its consumer chatbot app and AI Mode in Google Search, the last two of which have crossed 1 billion users.



GUJARAT INTERNATIONAL FINANCE TEC-CITY COMPANY LIMITED (GIFTCL)

Notice for Invitation to Bid

Gujarat International Finance Tec-City Company Limited, invites bids from reputed, qualified, experienced and financially sound Bidders for the following Assignment:

Name of the Assignment	Online availability of RFP Document	Last Date of Online & Physical Submission
Empanelment of Human Resource Recruitment Agencies for GIFTCL (RFP Ref. No. GIFT/HR/RFP/2026/02)	01st October 2026 to 21st October 2026 up to 17:00 hrs	22nd October 2026 on or before 15:00 hrs

RFP document may be downloaded online from website at <https://tender.nprocure.com>

Tender fee of RFP document is Rs.2,000/- payable in the form of Demand Draft / Banker's Cheque / Pay Order drawn in favor of "Gujarat International Finance Tec-City Company Limited" payable at Ahmedabad. For further details and updates please log on to our Website www.giftgujarat.in and <https://tender.nprocure.com>

Contact Person:

GM (P & C)

Tel: 079-61708300 E-mail: contract@giftgujarat.in

Sd/-
Managing Director & Group CEO

Gujarat International Finance Tec-City Company Limited (GIFTCL)

EPS Building No.49A, Block 49, Zone 04, Gyan Marg, GIFT City, Gujarat, INDIA. Pin-382050.

Tel.: +91 79 61708300, CIN:U65929GJ2007PLC051160

mint lounge

LIVING WITH BOOKS

Lounge meets some uncommon readers to understand how reading, buying, losing and returning to books has shaped their lives

THINK: Stop policing school lunch boxes

TASTE: What Michelin guides could bring to India

TRAVEL: The little-known mangroves of Honnavar

CULTURE: Still searching for Zahir Raihan

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

Spend Sunday discovering something new.

HT wknd
A PART OF YOUR EVERYDAY LIFE

READ EVERY SUNDAY





BSE Sensex			Nifty 50			Nifty 500			Nifty Next 50			Nifty 100			BSE 150 MidCap			BSE 250 SmallCap		
CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE		CLOSE	PERCENT CHANGE	
71,909.70	-0.79		22,421.95	-0.88		21,857.75	-0.97		68,981.35	-1.10		23,516.50	-0.92		15,997.57	-0.99		6,909.40	-1.23	
PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN	PREVIOUS CLOSE		OPEN
72,480.29		72,192.89	22,620.45		22,543.70	22,072.10		22,005.00	69,746.95		69,531.05	23,734.70		23,655.50	16,156.98		16,117.04	6,995.30		6,977.09
HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW	HIGH		LOW
72,572.90		71,292.80	22,610.60		22,217.30	22,046.80		21,623.25	69,683.90		68,110.50	23,722.00		23,286.70	16,140.86		15,788.24	6,977.29		6,818.23

Mfg PMI's dead cat bounce

Harsha Jethmalani
harsha.j@livemint.com

Business momentum in India's manufacturing sector has taken a U-turn. The seasonally adjusted HSBC India Manufacturing Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) rose to a seven-month high of 55.1 in September after hitting a five-year low of 52.8 in August. Faster increases in new orders and output aided recovery and supported job creation. Higher demand for electronic, food, pharmaceutical and textile products drove a sharper increase in new business intakes.

Indian manufacturers upgraded their output forecasts. The PMI sub-index gauging business confidence rose to a four-month high in September. This optimism was underpinned by new enquiries in the pipeline and expectations that demand conditions will remain favourable, said the PMI survey. In line with future sales expectations, companies increased stocks. Holdings of finished products rose for the third month in a row in September

One month wonder?

India's manufacturing PMI hit a seven-month high in September, driving increased confidence among firms.



and at the second-fastest pace in 11-and-a-half years.

But this may well be a one-month wonder. The PMI average for July-September stood at 53.8, its lowest since the same period in 2021. With Brent crude oil at \$98 per barrel levels and food inflation set to pinch harder, the road ahead for the

Indian economy is bumpy.

"The macro-outlook is likely to become more challenging in Q3FY27, as the weak and uneven monsoon, alongside rising El Niño risks, could feed into food prices," said Motilal Oswal Financial Services on 25 September.

High input costs are adding pres-

sure across transportation, energy and manufacturing activities. In August, inflation measured via the wholesale price index (WPI) surged to 10%. Inflation measured via the consumer price index (CPI) or retail inflation rose to 4.82% with food inflation at 5.95%. "The gap

DEMAND BOOST

THE PMI sub-index gauging business confidence rose to a four-month high in September

STRONG demand for electronics, food, pharma and textiles drove higher new business intakes

food prices, tighter liquidity and elevated borrowing costs would dent customers' purchasing power, thus weighing on credit-sensitive sectors and consumption. For manufacturers, there is little room to raise prices and protect margins.

The PMI survey showed that higher prices for electronic components, pharma items and steel pushed up overall cost burdens in September. The rate of input cost inflation accelerated from August, but remained below its long-run average.

Selling prices also increased at a quicker pace, but the increase was modest. "In Q1FY27, companies were able to

pass on some of the rise in input costs to consumers which supported profit growth. The longer the supply-shock persists, companies will continue to pass on input cost pressures to consumers and after a point, sales volume growth could moderate," Sen Gupta added.

Can tech fix ICICI Lombard's underwriting equation?

Ananya Roy
feedback@livemint.com

ICICI Lombard General Insurance Co.'s Digital Day meet on Tuesday has raised hopes of improving the insurer's profits from its recent slump. The stock gained 4% the next day.

The management showcased how tech is moving from a back-office enabler to being integrated across the entire business, from underwriting, risk management and pricing to distribution, claims and servicing.

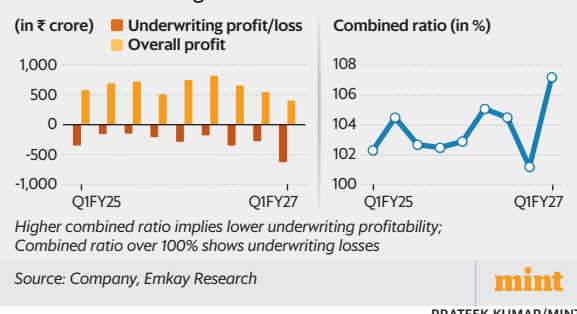
The digital share of its servicing has expanded from

20% in FY23 to 47% in FY26, and further to 71% in Q1FY27, aiming for 90% by FY29. Digital servicing costs 90% less than manual servicing. The insurer's share of digital sourcing is also set to expand from 6% to 15%, which, along with the shrinkage in product launch time (6 months versus 4 weeks), can bring in 3-5% of gross written premium from new launches by FY29.

The digital leap is expected to translate into 100-200 basis points higher growth versus the industry, a sustained 10+ percentage point advantage in combined ratio, and 17-20% return on equity

Core drag

ICICI Lombard has made profits despite losses in its core underwriting business.



(RoE). Combined ratio measures underwriting profitability; it is the ratio of claims paid and other operating expenses

to premiums earned.

The timing is important, as its stock has fallen 13% since Q1FY27 earnings after the

combined ratio worsened to 107.2%, from 102.9% a year ago. Excluding large fire claims and regulation-driven higher provisions, it would have been 102.3%. A higher combined ratio means lower underwriting profitability, while a ratio above 100% indicates an underwriting loss.

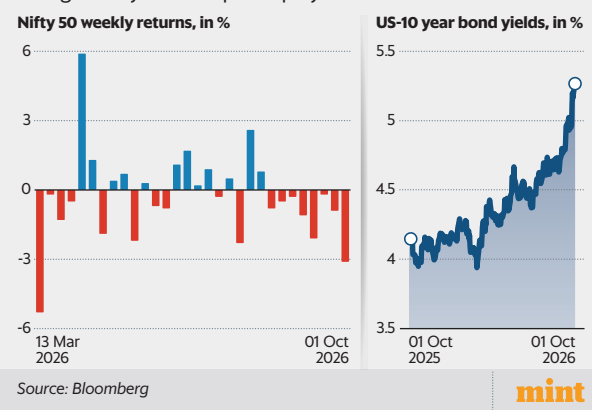
Notably, for FY26, ICICI Lombard's combined ratio was 103.4% versus the industry's 117.8%. ICICI's gross direct premium income grew 7.5% year-on-year to ₹8,318 crore in Q1. But dragged down by deeper underwriting losses, net profit fell 46% to ₹403 crore despite invest-

ment profits. RoE fell from 21% to 10%. While Irdai's tighter commission and expense-of-management norms proposed last month are expected to trigger a reset of the industry, ICICI Lombard's management expects large-scale multi-channel, multi-product insurers like itself to sustain on top.

The stock has remained largely flat over five years, and is trading at 23 times FY28 earnings based on consensus Bloomberg estimates. A rerating will hinge on whether the promised tech-led efficiencies can lead to underwriting profitability.

Stock slop

Rising bond yields deepen equity losses.



Eight-week slide puts focus on RBI

Mayur Bhalerao
mayur.bhalerao@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Cheaper oil failed to bring much comfort for Indian equities as the markets slid for the eighth consecutive week. Nifty 50 recorded its longest weekly losing streak since 2001 in a holiday-truncated week, with markets closed on Friday for Gandhi Jayanti. On Thursday, it fell 0.88% to 22,421.95, while the Sensex declined 0.79% to 71,909.69.

Their weekly losses stood at 3.11% and 2.69%, respectively, with the Nifty posting its sharpest weekly decline since the week ended 13 March 2026. The retreat has sharpened a question: Is a recovery in sight?

Prasenjit Paul, fund manager at I29 Wealth and head of research at Paul Asset, said elevated oil prices, rupee weakness and higher US bond yields were driving foreign outflows. Foreign portfolio investors sold a net ₹35,861 crore of equities in September, with ₹19,273 crore—53.7% of the monthly outflow—withdrawn in the final seven trading sessions. Selling continued on Thursday, with another ₹9,232 crore offloaded.

The US 10-year Treasury

yield climbed to around 5.3%, its highest since June 2007, while India's benchmark government bond yield hovered near 7.20%. Crude's retreat to about \$96.30 a barrel offered relief, but proved insufficient to reverse market sentiment.

On earnings trajectory, V.K. Vijayakumar, chief investment strategist, Geojit Investments Ltd notes that if crude prices remain elevated for long, economic growth and corporate earnings will be impacted.

"The market is concerned about this. In this context, 5.2% yield from the US 10-year bond becomes very attractive for FPIs," he added.

That assessment also faces a test at the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) Monetary Policy Committee meeting on 5-7 October.

September-quarter results will offer another test, beginning with Tata Consultancy Services on 8 October.

India also lagged most markets in the global snapshot. Only Indonesia's Jakarta Composite, down 3.72%, fell more than the Nifty. France's CAC 40 and South Korea's KRX100 lost 2.18% and 2.04%, respectively.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Consumption rises, investment recovery lags AI funds favour Taiwan, Korea over India

Niti Kiran & Abhinaba Saha
MUMBAI

The economy's two primary growth engines—consumption and investment—are moving at divergent speeds. While private consumption gained traction—rising 7.1% in the June quarter against 6.8% a year ago—investment has been uneven so far this fiscal year.

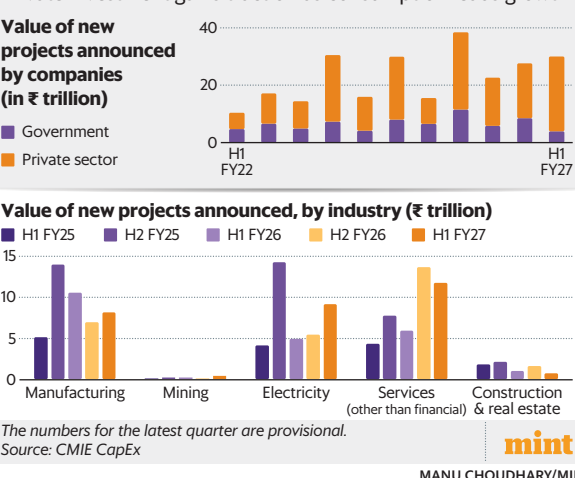
At first glance, new project announcements rose 33% year-on-year (y-o-y) during the April-September (H1) period of fiscal year 2027 (FY27) to ₹30 trillion, following a 46% surge in the corresponding period last fiscal year. New announcements rose 8.4% over H2FY26, according to Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE) data. However, a close look at the quarterly trend reveals the lopsided nature of these announcements. New project proposals in the September quarter contracted nearly 6% y-o-y, after a stellar 69% surge in the June quarter, and dropped almost 50% sequentially.

Moreover, India's entire private capex trajectory hinges on just two non-traditional sectors: data centres and nuclear power. They accounted for 25% of all capex proposals in September and almost 75% of all June-quarter announcements. Strip away the heavy concentration of these mega-investments, and the yearly decline in the September quarter deepens to 29%.

This reflects a broader "three-dimensional" concentration problem in India's private capex cycle, said Apoorva

Capex divergence

Private investment gains traction as consumption leads growth.



Javadekar, chief economist at Shriram Group. He said investments are driven by a handful of large companies, concentrated in a few states, including Maharashtra, Gujarat, Rajasthan, Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh, and across a narrow set of sectors, notably power, data centres and semiconductors.

Key private mega-ventures announced during July-September included Adani Enterprises' Odisha Integrated Greenfield Aluminium Project worth ₹1.1 trillion, the Naraj Hyperscale AI Data Centre Hub Project worth ₹1.04 trillion and the Bhiv Bunder Nuclear Power Project (₹0.4 trillion), CMIE data showed.

Overall, projects worth ₹10.2 trillion were announced during this period, of which govern-

ment projects accounted for ₹1.3 trillion, while private-sector projects totalled ₹8.8 trillion. On a yearly basis, private projects were down nearly 27%, whereas private sector announcements fell roughly 2%. Beyond the two emerging segments of data centres and

India's private capex trajectory hinges on just two non-traditional sectors: data centres and nuclear power

investments in H1 FY27 compared with the same period last year.

Javadekar noted that micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs), which are a key source of new manufacturing capacity, have come under pressure as higher debt servicing costs for supply chain and

working capital financing have coincided with shrinking profits in the post-Covid period. This has constrained their ability to fund large capex projects through bank financing.

Meanwhile, intentions in construction and real estate plummeted 31.5%, CMIE data showed. This left other conventional segments, like mining and electricity, to cushion the broader slowdown. New project announcements across both sectors nearly doubled in H1FY27 compared to H1FY26.

Looking ahead, Javadekar expects continued US tariff uncertainty to pose a significant risk to India Inc's export-linked capex decisions, potentially keeping new project announcements concentrated in data centres, power, and nuclear projects. Even after negotiations, India faces an 18% US tariff on exports, with the added risk of 100% tariffs on Russian oil purchases under the Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026.

"Tariff uncertainty has not only affected capex plans within SEZs (special economic zones) but also stands to destabilize the FDI (Foreign Direct Investment) momentum for firms targeting India as an export hub," he said.

This is the final part of a five-part series evaluating the first half of fiscal year 2027. The first part examined the performance of domestic markets, the second looked at the best-performing asset classes, the third covered trends in private consumption, while the fourth assessed the primary markets.

niti.k@livemint.com

Dipti Sharma
dipti.sharma@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Artificial intelligence (AI) markets are starting to see outflows. India isn't getting the money.

Taiwan and South Korea, two of the biggest beneficiaries of the global AI investment boom, are showing early signs of cooling investor enthusiasm. But India, expected to benefit from any such rotation, is still seeing foreign money leave.

Since June, Taiwan- and South Korea-dedicated funds have attracted \$23.5 billion and \$28.4 billion, respectively, while India has seen outflows of \$4.5 billion, said Sumit Jain, vice president at Elara Capital.

Over the past six weeks, however, Taiwan has recorded outflows of \$796 million, South Korea \$3.17 billion and India \$1.48 billion. "So, it is only since the past six weeks, where we are seeing very early signs of redemptions from the two AI economies. India outflows also continue but the relative momentum is now turning better," he said.

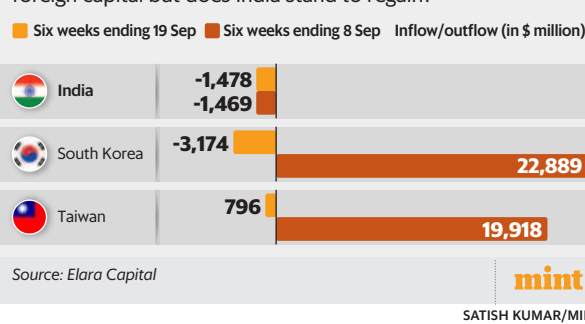
The early outflows from Taiwan and South Korea may mark a pause in the AI trade, but there is little evidence yet of the money moving to India.

Taiwan and Korea are closely linked markets, driven by the AI theme.

They are benefiting from a global AI capex boom that has created supply shortages, while the supply response is likely to take time, said Nitin Jain, chief executive, Kotak Asset Management Singapore.

Taking a turn for the better?

Past six weeks, South Korea and Taiwan have seen a flight of foreign capital but does India stand to regain?



Trade restrictions arising from US-China tensions have further constrained supply, boosting profitability in the near to medium term.

But concerns over US AI spending, cash flows and profitability have triggered bouts of volatility in the AI theme, leading to sharp swings across some segments, he said.

"The inflows in these mar-

kets reflected the optimism of investors in AI investments and the superiority and even exclusivity of some of the businesses in Taiwan/Korea to exploit the upsurge in the AI investments and the recent outflows reflect more the recent volatility in the theme and some profit booking rather than long term disbelief," Jain noted.

India, meanwhile, had been losing money as emerging-market investors reallocated towards the AI theme.

Tariffs and oil prices, along with the perceived negative

impact of AI on India, outweighed the positives from economic growth and earnings, Jain said.

Broader foreign investor inflows also remain tentative. After buying ₹23,331.85 crore in July and ₹22,846.78 crore in August, foreign institutional investors (FIIs) turned sellers again in September, offloading shares worth ₹43,001.52

crore, according to data from BSE and National Securities Depository Ltd.

The modest improvement reflects, to some extent, a growing confidence in corporate earnings and the resilience of the economy despite high oil prices and geopolitical risks, said market participants. But foreign inflows have yet to show a broad-based shift.

The rise in US 10-year Treasury yields could weigh on emerging-market sentiment. While large FCNR inflows will help mitigate risks for India, elevated energy prices and

ings and the resilience of the economy despite high oil prices and geopolitical risks, said market participants. But foreign inflows have yet to show a broad-based shift.

yields could keep investors cautious despite resilient growth and strong corporate earnings.

Spot Brent crude oil prices have shot up nearly 66% in 2026, while the US 10-year Treasury yield has risen around 28%, according to Bloomberg data.

"Oil remains the principal risk, but if prices stay contained, strong growth, improving earnings and currency stability could help revive foreign investor interest," said Vinay Jaising, chief investment officer and head-equity, ASK Private Wealth.

India's relative position appears to be improving, although it is too early to call this a decisive shift, he said.

More importantly, Jaising believes confirmation would require sustained redemptions from the two AI-heavy markets alongside consistent inflows into India.

But the flows do not show that yet, said Lokesh Manik, senior analyst at Vallum Capital. Taiwan and Korea have swung from inflows to outflows, but India has not regained investor favour; the AI trade has simply paused.

For now, therefore, an artificial intelligence-trade pause is not the same as an India rotation.

Manik does not expect a return to broad-based rallies. With US 10-year yields at 5% and crude above \$100, returns are likely to come from a handful of micro themes with concentrated leadership, making this a stock-pickers' market.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com



Anup Bagchi named HDFC Bank chief for three years

Bagchi returns to banking after 3 years in insurance, having spent most of his career at ICICI

Shayan Ghosh
shayan.g@livemint.com
MUMBAI

The Reserve Bank of India on Thursday approved the appointment of ICICI Group veteran Anup Bagchi as the chief executive of India's largest private lender, HDFC Bank, for a three-year term from 27 October.

Bagchi, 56, was widely seen as the top contender for the post, alongside internal candidate Kaizad M Bharucha. For Bagchi, the appointment marks a return to banking after three years in insurance. This also helps retain ICICI Bank's tag as the chief executive factory, having produced several top leaders scattered across financial services.

The appointment is also the second instance in recent years of an insurance executive being brought in to lead a bank. In 2019, Amitabh Chaudhry joined Axis Bank as chief executive from HDFC Life Insurance Company.

The vacancy at HDFC Bank arose from incumbent CEO Sashidhar Jagdishan's decision not to seek a third term. Having joined the bank in February 1996, Jagdishan rose through the ranks to become chief financial officer in 2008 and then chief executive in 2020, after Aditya Puri stepped down.

The central bank's decision also ends speculation over who will lead the \$119-billion private lender, which was mired in multiple controversies in recent months, including the sudden and dramatic departure of then-chairman Atanu Chakraborty, and allegations surrounding its preferential treatment of a particular bulk depositor.

Bagchi's former colleagues describe him as an intelligent executive who can work the room and get things moving quickly. While at ICICI Bank, he was credited with creating a product that



Anup Bagchi's appointment follows Sashidhar Jagdishan's decision not to seek a third term, ending a leadership transition at HDFC Bank.

gave risk assessment teams a better grip over customer cash flow. Under him, the bank launched lending to small businesses based on their goods and services tax (GST) returns in 2018. "Earlier, it was very difficult to assess

ascertain the volume of sales and customer footfall and find out whether it does the kind of business it claims to do. "That changed with GST and therefore the bank's product was timely," he said. A chemical engineer from IIT Kan-

pur over the course of his career at ICICI.

He led ICICI Securities from May 2011 to October 2016. His elevation from an executive director to CEO at ICICI Securities came in 2011 after Madhabi Puri Buch — who later became the chair of Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) — moved to another group entity. Bagchi returned to the bank as an executive director in February 2017.

Apart from sensing business opportunities, Bagchi has a history of working on key regulatory committees. He was a member of RBI's committee on small businesses in 2019 and of a Sebi committee on financial and regulatory technologies in 2017, among others.

"The good part is that since Bagchi is young, he can easily serve for a long tenure say nine, 12 years, and hence can come with a long-term view and vision to change the bank of course subjected to the board and RBI approvals," Suresh Ganapathy, managing director, Macquarie Capital said in an email to clients on 22 September.

Under RBI regulations, private bank chiefs can be at the helm for up to 15 years or till they turn 70.

However, Ganapathy cautioned that an external candidate who gets appointed will have to deal with senior management exits, and the top priority for a new external CEO is to stabilise the senior management and control attrition levels.

He said that the priority of the new chief executive will be to drive up the retail growth, particularly on the retail unsecured side, and focus more on CASA (current and savings account). He also has to enhance the tech architecture and make the bank more tech-savvy; improve service culture as we believe there is a gap here, said Ganapathy.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

RBI clears Anup Kumar Saha as Kotak Bank MD & CEO

Subhana Shaikh
subhana.shaikh@livemint.com
MUMBAI

For Anup Kumar Saha, his ambition to run a bank has finally materialized. The Reserve Bank of India has approved his candidature for the top role at Kotak Mahindra Bank, eight months after he joined the lender.

The central bank approved a three-year term for 56-year-old Saha late on Wednesday, starting 1 January 2027.

Saha, who joined the bank in January, has been overseeing the retail bank, data analytics and marketing functions since March. He is currently a whole-time director at the bank. The bank said its board of directors will take further steps to formalize Saha's appointment and seek shareholders' approval.

In June 2025, Saha, then the managing director of consumer financier Bajaj Finance, stepped down just three months after taking over the role. He had joined Bajaj in 2017 after spending 14 years at ICICI Bank and was reported to be among the three contenders for the top job at private lender IndusInd Bank. The position eventually went to Rajiv Anand, who recently retired from Axis Bank.

At Kotak, Saha will succeed Ashok Vaswani, who has been the bank's chief since January 2024. Vaswani earlier decided not to seek another term for personal reasons.

"We view the appointment positively given Saha's strong retail banking background," analysts at Jefferies said in a note. "...Saha has extensive



Anup Kumar Saha will take over the reins on 1 January 2027 for a three-year term, succeeding Ashok Vaswani.

experience leading retail segments at Bajaj Finance and ICICI Bank; timely team reorganisation, if any, will help."

The appointment was largely anticipated by investors, it said. Kotak Bank stock rose over 4% to Rs 435.6 apiece following the announcement, before settling at Rs 418.35. The stock has gained around 10% over the past two months, compared with a 4% fall in the Nifty Bank index.

Many believe that his retail-banking experience went in

his favour. "Anup is a seasoned financial services leader with deep experience across businesses, customer segments and operating functions. Since joining Kotak, he has worked

closely with our teams and demonstrated a clear understanding of the opportunities ahead," Vaswani was quoted as saying in the press release.

His industry colleagues describe him as a simple man who focuses on execution.

According to a person aware of Saha's working style, he is extremely involved with the team and is a hands-on leader, and likes to keep his ear to the

ground. Given that 40% of Kotak Mahindra Bank's loanbook is from the retail segments, Saha could prove to be the right man for the job. "There are leaders who can be intimidating. Saha is not," said the person cited above.

Saha brings more than 32 years of professional experience, including 25 years in financial services across banking and non-banking financial institutions. Before joining Kotak, he held several senior leadership positions at Bajaj Finance, culminating in his appointment as managing director in April 2025.

At ICICI Bank, he led businesses and functions including retail secured assets, business intelligence, retail and rural collections, credit cards and retail structured finance.

He began his career with GE Capital, where he worked across credit cards, sales and analytics, and later worked with Bharat Heavy Electricals Limited (BHEL) in production engineering. Saha holds a B.Tech degree in Engineering from IIT Kharagpur and an MBA from IIM Lucknow.

Saha said he was grateful to the board for the opportunity to lead the bank.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Alliance Insurance Brokers set for ₹900-cr minority stake sale

Priyamvada C
priyamvada.c@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Alliance Insurance Brokers has initiated a process to sell a minority stake to raise about ₹800-900 crore through a mix of primary and secondary share sale, two people familiar with the matter said.

"The company will sell about a 30% stake to raise capital from institutional investors. It has roped in O3 Capital as an advisor to help with the process," one of the people cited above said. The person added that the round will see existing investor Access Asset Managers exit its 10-year-old stake in the company.

The company will likely use the fresh proceeds to deepen its presence across tier 2 and 3 areas in India, while expanding its footprint in reinsurance in global markets, including West Asia and Africa, through organic and inorganic plans, the second person said.



The firm is eyeing ₹800-900 cr for a 30% stake sale. ISTOCKPHOTO

The final contours of the deal may change depending on the nature of the incoming investor, they said. Both the people spoke on the condition of anonymity as the discussions are still private.

Emails sent to Access, Alliance and O3 Capital did not elicit a response till press time.

India's insurance sector has seen significant growth, with the domestic market growing at a compound annual growth rate (CAGR) of 17% over the

past two decades, according to IBEF estimates. It is projected to reach ₹19.3 trillion by FY26. This growth has been driven by increased awareness, favourable regulatory changes, and greater participation from the private sector.

Founded in 2003 by industry veteran SV Thakkar, Mumbai-based Alliance Insurance is among India's leading insurance service providers, risk managers and reinsurance brokers. It serves as a one-stop solution for a wide range of services like tailor-made insurance solutions, claims management, insurance audit and renewal reviews.

The company is currently run by second-generation entrepreneur Aatur Thakkar, who was named as the chief executive officer earlier this year. In 2016, Access invested ₹55 crore for about 25-26% stake in Alliance, as per media reports, while the remaining is held by the promoters.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Dilip Buildcon aims to double coal output by FY29

Subhash Narayan
subhash.narayan@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Engineering and infrastructure firm Dilip Buildcon Ltd (DBL) is aggressively scaling up its mining portfolio. It is targeting an annual coal production of 57 million tonnes (MT) by FY29 while expanding into other minerals like bauxite to establish mining as a core earnings driver alongside its traditional engineering, procurement, and construction (EPC) business, managing director and chief executive officer Devendra Jain told *Mint*.

Having produced 28.72 MT of coal in FY26, DBL expects output to nearly double over the next three years. This growth will be led by the ramp-up of its key mine developer and operator projects: Siarmal in Odisha and Pachhara in Jharkhand. The company also holds an MDO contract for the ₹1,750 crore Pottangi Bauxite Mines in Odisha.

Siarmal production is expected to rise from 25 MT in FY26 to 30 MT in FY27, 35 MT in FY28 and 50 MT in FY29. Pachhara is expected to operate at its contracted annual capacity of 7 MT through FY29, Jain said.

He added that DBL has also demonstrated diversification beyond coal, citing the ₹1,750 crore Pottangi Bauxite Mines, where the company has secured a MDO contract, as an example. "The broader strategy is to widen the mineral base, including new mine-development mandates in India and overseas," Jain said.



The firm is expanding beyond coal into minerals such as bauxite, with a ₹1,750 cr MDO contract for Pottangi mines in Odisha. AFP

DBL is also looking at consolidated coal production of about 57 MT by FY29. "DBL is moving towards an integrated, asset-led infrastructure model, where its EPC capabilities support the development and operation of long-duration assets," Jain said.

DBL produced 22.35 MT from Siarmal and 6.37 MT from Pachhara in FY26. In addition, the bauxite project at Pottangi has a stated capacity of 3.5 MTPA and a mine life of 22 years. Pottangi is not included in the 57 MT coal

production target, Jain said.

The company aims to generate about 75% of its total profit and cash flows from long-term mining and infrastructure-asset businesses by FY29. This would reduce EPC share to 25%. The EPC business contributed around 60% of consolidated profits in FY26. "The target relates to the share of consolidated

profit contribution from the two businesses. The company expects the majority of this 75% contribution to come from mining, although it is not providing a precise split between mining and infrastructure assets," Jain said.

The shift reflects the higher contribution that is expected from mining as production scales up further. Mining revenue increased from ₹45.9 crore in 2022-23 to ₹1,574.6 crore in FY26, while the combined coal production at Siarmal and Pachhara increased from 0.5 MT to 28.72 MT dur-

ing the same period.

"The mining business typically offers higher margins than conventional EPC, but it is also fundamentally different and more capital-intensive. Our increasing focus on mining is therefore not driven by margins alone. It is primarily about building a portfolio of longer-term contracts and creating greater predictability and visibility in cash flows," Jain said.

DBL expects to scale Siarmal without making additional investments at the parent-company level. The project is housed in a special purpose vehicle that has its own financial tie-up, with debt tied up with two leading banks, Jain said. DBL has no additional capex obligations or funding commitments toward the project. The company is currently relying on organic growth to expand its mining portfolio, Jain said.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

'AI startups face high costs to scale and monetize'

Rwit Ghosh
rwit.ghosh@livemint.com
BENGALURU

India's consumer artificial intelligence-focused companies in segments such as education, content and healthcare will have to navigate increased compute costs, value consciousness from customers and changing retention metrics if they want to scale up and monetize, according to a top executive at global venture capital firm Lightspeed India.

"We are sort of back in a way to 12 years ago, when it was hard to monetize India," said Harsha Kumar, a partner at Lightspeed India. "We're going to go through that journey again. Founders will have to be smart about what they



Harsha Kumar, partner, Lightspeed India.

build and how they build and how they monetize."

Venture investors have been looking more closely at the consumer AI segment and began allocating capital to it last year. Most are betting that the next set of large companies

will emerge across health, education and entertainment. But as Indian companies build AI apps for consumers, computing costs will be an inhibitor in a business that is already expensive to scale.

Compute costs are expenses

incurred on processing power, hardware and energy required every time a consumer interacts with AI. Demand for AI hardware such as graphics processing units exceeds supply and is driving cloud rental and hardware lease rates higher.

"Compute pricing keeps founders from building more mass-market solutions. Even now, founders have to build more vertical companies so they can actually have margins. It'll be a challenge for a few years at least."

Indian startup founders are willing to wait a few months for cheaper open weight AI models to emerge from China

instead of paying the high fees to US companies for the use of, say, OpenAI's ChatGPT and Anthropic's Claude.

While Indian consumers are more willing to pay for online services, especially in areas

deemed important for growth such as education, retention continues to be a challenge. One way to solve this, is to focus more on providing outcomes. "I don't think there's such a thing as an addictive product, at least for India. We're value-conscious people. We like value. If there's no results, people will not stick," Kumar said.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).



Gujarat Electricity Regulatory Commission

6th Floor, GIFT ONE, Road 5C, Zone 5, GIFT City,
Dist.: Gandhinagar, Gujarat-382050.
(O) 079 23602000, (F) 079 23602054/55
e-mail-gerc@gercin.org Website: www.gercin.org

NOTICE INVITING REQUEST FOR PROPOSALS (RfP) FROM ELIGIBLE CONSULTANT

Gujarat Electricity Regulatory Commission (GERC) has issued a Request for Proposals (RfP) from competent/eligible consulting firms to provide consultancy support in the work of Tariff Orders for FY 2027-28 [Truing up for FY 2025-26, Approval of Revised ARR and Determination of Tariff for FY 2027-28].

For more details, please visit 'Latest News' at <https://gercin.org/news-category>. The last date for receiving proposal is **26.10.2026**. For future announcement, if any, in this regard, please keep referring to the above website.

Gift City, Gandhinagar
30/09/2026

Sd/-
Ranjeeth Kumar J., IAS
Secretary, GERC



Airtel Money eyes 5-year high UK IPO

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Mobile payments firm Airtel Money is looking to raise £529 million (\$700 million) for its shareholders in what could be London's biggest initial public offering in five years.

Existing investors including the Qatar Investment Authority and Mastercard Inc. are selling shares at a fixed price of £1.96, which would give Airtel Money, officially Airtel Mobile Commerce NV, a market value of £5.3 billion, according to terms of the deal seen by Bloomberg.

The valuation is lower than the \$8 billion to \$9 billion range reported previously, implying a discount to boost demand.

Airtel Money's offering may be the largest for London's stock market since IPO volumes plummeted after a pandemic-era boom. A successful debut would bring new impetus to the city's efforts to attract international listings.

The selling investors are offering 270 million existing shares in the deal, while Bharti Airtel International may sell an additional 27 million shares through an overallotment option after the stock starts trading on the London Stock Exchange on 9 October. Airtel Money is expected to be eligible for inclusion in FTSE UK indexes.

Airtel Money is pushing ahead with the IPO, even as other firms delay their IPOs, both in Europe and the US. Fixing the price range enables Airtel Money to simplify the offering structure, which could help get the deal completed even if markets turn volatile.

Accenture predicts higher AI spending as token costs fall

Company's shares soar after upbeat management commentary; Infosys, Wipro rise on NYSE

Jas Bardia
jas.bardia@livemint.com
BENGALURU

Accenture Plc. expects companies to spend more on automation tools as the costs of deploying them reduce, even as it passes more productivity benefits to clients.

While overall tech budgets have remained largely unchanged from last year, newer and cheaper AI models offer clients an incentive to spend more on AI, Julie Sweet, chief executive of the world's largest IT services company said.

"So, the way we think about the dynamic is, the more that token costs go down over the next couple of years, the more it's going to enable companies to use AI in more places and at scale. And to use AI, they need to change their processes, reinvent their work, build out that AI stack in order to really do it. And all of that is what clients are turning to us," Sweet said at a post-earnings conference call.

A token is the fundamental unit of data processed by large language models (LLMs) such as OpenAI's ChatGPT or Anthropic's Claude. They are essentially AI's building blocks used to analyze and generate text, images and software codes.

Accenture's commentary comes on the back of AI advancements that have threatened to erode the revenue of tech services firms, as much of the work they handle can be automated by automation tools.

The management also added that AI-led revenue deflation, even though persistent, is now predictable.

"We are definitely giving more productivity due to AI, and overall, though, the impact has been steady. So, we're offsetting (revenue deflation) as we have in the past with new kinds of work,



Accenture's earnings cheered investors, with the company's shares rising 22% on the New York Stock Exchange.

more scope," she said.

The management's upbeat commentary was reflected in its report card. Accenture closed the fiscal year ended August with \$74.2 billion revenue, up 6% from the previous year. A little more than a fourth of its revenue growth

Shares of Infosys and Wipro followed as well, gaining 9% and 8%, respectively. Earnings were in line with its own estimates -- the company ended with a 5% growth in local currency, in line with its June estimates. The company bounced back from a period of low new

in revenue.

The company reported a net profit of \$8.5 billion, up 8.8% from the preceding year. Profitability jumped as well, with the company reporting 15.4% in operating margins, up 70 basis points from a year earlier. One basis point is a hundredth of a percentage point. The management attributed this to better deal pricing and delivery efficiencies.

The company expects revenue growth between 3-6% in local currency this year, of which 2-2.5% is expected to come from acquisitions.

"They have beaten expectations. Uptick in small deals which are discretionary in nature, quick mobilization of contracts which implies faster deal conversions to revenue, and better performance of recent acquisitions and Accenture Federal business have contributed to these numbers, which were better-than-expected," said Karan Uppal, lead IT analyst at Phillip Capital.

Accenture's earnings and commentary are seen as a bellwether for India's IT services sector, with some of the country's largest tech services firms including Tata Consultancy Services Ltd, Infosys Ltd, HCL Technologies Ltd and Wipro Ltd, announcing their

second quarter results beginning next week. To be sure, Accenture follows a September-August fiscal calendar, compared to Indian IT's April-March.

"Overall positive readthroughs for Indian IT companies -- There is no further pressure on pricing and client spending is intact for digital core, data foundation and enterprise AI," Uppal of Phillips Capital said.

The company expects about \$8 billion in acquisitions this year, even as \$3 billion is expected from cybersecurity deals that were deferred to last month.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com



MOVES

A weekly list of C-Suiters who have moved up the corporate ladder either within or outside their companies.

Anup Deshmukh	Appointed as India managing director at Danfoss Power Solutions
Bhavna Kumar	Appointed as managing director—human resources at BNP Paribas India
Bhavna Singh	Appointed as head—corporate communications at EssilorLuxottica India
Bijon Pani	Appointed as chief investment officer—alternatives at Godrej Asset Management
Deepak Somasundaram	Appointed as chief human resources officer at Chettinad Group
Dheeraj Kumar Rai	Appointed as director—manufacturing at Carraro India
Dr. Rajan Pental	Appointed as financial services sector leader at PwC India
Gaurav Hazrati	Appointed as business head—loyalty, marketplaces & financial services at IndiGo
Gautam Mehra	Appointed as chief human resources officer at IFP Petro
Geetika Mishra	Appointed as chief procurement officer at Spark Minda
Karthik Krishnamurthy	Appointed as global chief executive officer at Wipro Aerospace
Kunal Jha	Appointed as chief financial officer at Webasto
Laxminarayan Toshniwal	Appointed as CFO at Voith India Region, & CFO at Voith Hydro
Manish Bhardwaj	Appointed as senior vice-president & chief human resources officer at Emami Agrotech
Nupur Shrivastava	Appointed as chief human resources officer at MiPhi Semiconductors
Partha Ghosh	Appointed as executive vice-president & group head—communications at JSW Group
Pooja Venkatram	Appointed as director & head—human resources at BASF India
Priyaranjan Jha	Appointed as global head—GCCs & country president, India at Sandoz India
Radhika Arora	Appointed as chief human resources officer at DCM Shriram Chemicals
Samir Dewan	Appointed as group chief executive officer at BajajCapital
Shweta Govil Singh	Appointed as chief human resources officer at Shriram Farm Solutions
Sudarshan Patodia	Appointed as chief financial officer at Rainbow Children's Medicare
Sudhanshu Tripathi	Appointed as chief marketing officer at Nucleus Software
Sudip Nag	Appointed as managing director at Jindal Power Ltd
Suman Yadav	Appointed as chief human resources officer at Wakefit Innovations
Suresh Venkatesan	Appointed as whole-time director & CEO at CRIF Credit Information Services
Umang Papneja	Appointed as executive vice-chairman & chief executive officer at Avendus Wealth Management
Upendra Chaturvedi	Appointed as chief technology officer at Bandhan Bank
Vaibhav Verma	Appointed as chief supply chain officer at Crystal Crop Protection

Source: Accord India, executive search worldwide

HC nixes Vedanta plea on bauxite pact

Dipali Banka & Nehal Chaliawala
MUMBAI

In a setback to Vedanta Ltd, the Orissa High Court on Thursday dismissed the conglomerate's plea seeking enforcement of a 2004 agreement with the Odisha Mining Corp (OMC) for supply of 150 million tonnes of bauxite at prices linked to production costs and royalty.

The ruling could sharply raise the cost of bauxite for its aluminium business, putting pressure on a key cost advantage for one of India's largest producers of the metal.

The division bench of the court held that Vedanta could not rely on agreements that had been terminated and had become unworkable following changes in mining law. The petition was filed by undivided Vedanta Ltd in 2023.

The ruling is significant as bauxite is the key raw material for Vedanta's Lanjigarh refinery, which supplies alumina to its aluminium smelters.



The ruling could sharply raise the cost of bauxite for Vedanta's aluminium business.

Vedanta had argued that it had made large investments in Odisha based on an assurance from the state that it would receive long-term bauxite supplies at a stable price.

Vedanta said it had invested more than ₹6,000 crore in setting up its Lanjigarh alumina refinery and had to initially source bauxite from outside because supplies from the proposed mines did not begin. This led to losses of more than ₹3,000 crore, it told the court.

Under the 2004 agreement, OMC had agreed to supply 150

million tonnes of bauxite to Vedanta with pricing linked to the cost of production and a royalty component.

Vedanta later sought to retain this pricing framework under the state's 2018 Long Term Linkage (LTL) policy, under which the floor price for auctions was linked to cost of production plus a 50% margin.

The dispute arose after Odisha changed the pricing mechanism following a 2019 amendment to Rule 45 of the Minerals (Other than Atomic and Hydro Carbons Energy Minerals) Concession Rules. The state directed OMC to use the average sale price method to fix the floor price for bauxite sold through national e-auctions.

Vedanta challenged the move, arguing the rule was meant for mine auctions and not for commercial sale of mined bauxite. It said the change had substantially increased its input costs.

The court rejected the argument, noting OMC had terminated the earlier JV pacts in September 2015 after changes to the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Act. Vedanta did not challenge the termination at the time, and it had therefore attained finality, it said.

"The company is evaluating the order and the legal recourse available to it. The order does not impact the supply of bauxite to Vedanta Aluminium," a company spokesperson said in an email response. OMC did not respond.

The court has allowed OMC to take further action in accordance with law, including raising demands based on the average sale price methodology. It also vacated interim orders that had protected Vedanta over the proceedings.

dipali.banka@livemint.com
For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

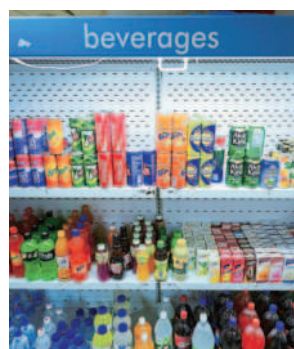
PepsiCo, Monster challenge label ban

Reuters
feedback@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

PepsiCo and Monster Beverage have sued India's food regulator for banning their use of the "energy drink" label, non-public court filings show, escalating a regulatory fight that has jolted a sector expected to be worth \$1.6 billion by 2028.

The food safety regulator ordered makers of high-caffeine beverages sold as "energy drinks" to stop using the description on 30 June amid growing concerns about the health risk of such products - part of an unprecedented food safety crackdown.

In a court filing in New Delhi, PepsiCo India said the prohibition will have "grave commercial consequences" and hurt "substantial investments," given that it had 492 million bottles and 26 million cans with those labels in circulation on 31 July.



The use of the 'energy drink' label has been banned.

PepsiCo was not given an opportunity to explain its position before the directive, and so the decision should be set aside, said the 358-page 29 September filing, which is not public and has not appeared in media but was seen by Reuters.

The regulator privately gave the companies 90 days to drop "energy drink", or any similar description, from high-caffeine beverages, saying that using that term breached regulations, Reuters has reported.

Healthy realty projects may escape pain from developer's bankruptcy

FROM PAGE 1

Raheja Developers, Supertech, Today Homes and Ajnara—or their arms—are facing bankruptcy proceedings. However, it is not clear yet if the new regulations would apply to these ongoing cases as well or only to fresh ones. A decision on the issue will soon be taken and notified, the people said.

The Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, as amended in April, also backs project-wise insolvency.

The IBBI has not estimated the number of projects and homebuyers likely to benefit from the regulation tweak, said the people cited above. The number of dwelling units in India's stalled real estate projects was pegged at 4,12,000 with a total value of ₹4.08 trillion, as per an Indian

Banks' Association estimate, cited in a July 2023 report of an expert panel led by former G20 Sherpa Amitabh Kant.

Of these, more than half were in the National Capital Region alone. These included assets of realtors facing insolvency resolution. As per the new framework, once the CoC is formed after the bankruptcy application against a real estate developer is admitted, it will be able to conduct a project-wise analysis and suggest exclusion of projects that don't require insolvency intervention.

Queries emailed to the insolvency regulator and to the corporate affairs ministry on Wednesday remained unanswered until press time.

Project-wise insolvency in real estate has been debated at length in recent years, and the current proposal draws from a discussion paper that the IBBI

had floated in late June.

"It will be a project-wise treatment after insolvency admission of the developer and formation of the CoC, so that the CoC can take an accurate and well-informed decision," said one of the people cited above, requesting anonymity.

A second person in the know concurred. "Project exclusion is being left to the CoC's wisdom, but ultimately, it has to be approved by the NCLT," this person said.

Anoop Rawat, partner and national practice head (Insolvency & Restructuring) at Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas & Co, said: "This provision is necessary because it shifts the resolution approach from corporate debtor rescue to project rescue and homebuyer rescue, which is what the Supreme Court, in the Mansi



Project-wise insolvency in real estate has been debated at length in recent years.

Bar case, said was needed."

In the Mansi Bar case last year, the apex court observed that real estate insolvency should, as a rule, proceed on a project-specific basis rather than against the entire corporate debtor, barring exceptional circumstances. It also

directed the IBBI to frame guidelines for realty insolvency, in consultation with the Real Estate Regulatory Authority (Rera).

The implementation of this plan is, however, going to be watched closely.

"A developer-debtor is a sin-

gle corporate entity and any credit facility provided to the developer does not get converted into a 'project finance', whereas a project-specific insolvency can operate in isolation by excluding the viable projects," said Yogendra Aldak, executive partner at Lakshmikumaran and Sridharan Attorneys.

To implement the proposal effectively, the regulator, in its June discussion paper, suggested mechanisms, such as enhanced project-wise disclosures, ring-fencing of funds, project-specific books, measures to account for homebuyer preferences, coordination between the resolu-

tion professional and the Rera, Aldak said. "The latest IBBI proposal addresses a genuine structural problem in real estate insolvency," said Vishal Gehrana, partner-designate at legal services firm Karanjawala & Co.

At the same time, safeguards need to be carefully worked out for its effective implementation, he said. "The regulation should clearly address who manages an excluded project, how existing creditor and home-

buyer interests are protected, what happens to the moratorium in relation to an excluded project, and how project assets, liabilities and funds are dealt with after exclusion,"

Gehrana said.

For context, when a developer goes into the CIRP, it triggers moratorium under Section 14 of the insolvency law without exceptions. This freezes prior payments for healthy, near-complete projects where there is no default, stopping construction, causing labour and contractor exit, blocking home loan disbursements and delaying home registrations, said Rawat.

This traps innocent homebuyers for years without possession or refund, while the cost of project completion escalates. Project-wise insolvency will help by ring-fencing the Section 14 moratorium and CIRP to only the defaulting projects, allowing construction, funding, possession and registration to continue unimpeded in all healthy projects, Rawat said.

To Get All The Popular Newspapers.
Save My Contact Number 8890050582 send Message telegram ya
Whatsapp

If You Want to get these Newspapers Daily at earliest

English Newspapers»»»

Indian Express, Financial Express, The Hindu, Business Line, The Times of India, The Economic Times, Hindustan Times, ET wealth, Business Standard, First India, Mint, Greater Kashmir, Greater Jammu, The Himalayan, The Tribune, Brill Express, The Sikh Times, Avenue Mail, Western Times, Millennium Post, The Statesman, State Times, The Pioneer, Hans India, Free Press, Orissa Post, Mumbai Mirror, Mid-Day, Deccan Chronicle, Deccan Herald, Telangana Today, Financial Times, The Asian Age, The Telegraph, Oheraldo, Gulf of Times, The New York Times, The Washington Post, Los Angeles Times, USA Today, The Wall Street Journal, The Guardian, The Times

Hindi Newspapers»»»

दैनिक जागरण, राजस्थान पत्रिका, दैनिक भास्कर, दिव्यभास्कर, हिंदुस्तान, नवभारत टाइम्स, बिज़नेस स्टैंडर्ड, अमर उजाला, जनसत्ता, द पायोनीर, राष्ट्रीय सहारा, प्रभातखबर, लोकसत्ता

Others»»»

Hindi & English Editorial, Employment News, Malayalam Newspapers, Tamil, Telugu, Urdu, Gujarati

Type in Search box of Telegram @NewsTG8 And you will find a Channel named NewsTG join it and receive daily editions of all popular newspapers at the earliest

Or

you can click on this link

<https://t.me/NewsTG8>



Hyundai announces interim salary hikes to curb attrition

Hyundai Motor India is also facing rising competition from Tata, Mahindra, VinFast and JSW

Ayaan Kartik
ayaan.kartik@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Hyundai Motor India's management has a new worry: talent leaving its ranks amid rising competition from homegrown carmakers Tata and Mahindra and the entry of VinFast and JSW Motors.

The management has noted rising attrition in many of its regional offices and is beginning a series of measures to curb it, starting with an immediate interim salary increase for employees, according to a person directly aware of the developments.

"There have been many exits in sales and marketing functions in regional offices, which has prompted the decision to roll out about a 1-2% salary hike on top of the annual hike," the person said.

Hyundai confirmed it is implementing an interim hike as part of employee welfare measures but denied there is any worry about rising attrition.

The turnover rate, a measure of the number of employees leaving a company, in the annual reports of Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles, Mahindra and Mahindra, and Hyundai India offer a clue.

For Hyundai, the rate rose in FY26, a year when its domestic sales declined by 2% to 584,906 cars as against the industry growth of 8% to 4.7 million units. Hyundai's permanent employee turnover rate increased to 7.94% in FY26 from 5% in FY25.

At Tata Motors PV, the turnover rate declined to 7.2% in FY26 from 8.6% in FY25. Mahindra and Mahindra's turnover rate declined marginally to 10.6% from 10.8% in the same period.

Hyundai India said in response to *Mint*'s queries that the company reviews its people policies and com-



Hyundai Motor India is giving employees an interim 1-2% salary hike, on top of the annual increment, to help retain talent. BLOOMBERG

pensation practices to ensure they remain fair, competitive, equitable and aligned with evolving employee expectations.

"The interim compensation revision is in line with our employee-centric philosophy and forms part of the vari-

ous employee welfare initiatives regularly undertaken by the company. We have one of the lowest attrition levels in the automobile industry in India and therefore, there is no question of our regular employee welfare activities being linked to the so-called 'attrition' referenced in your query. Hope this

clarifies," a company spokesperson said.

Experts noted that the rising churn comes with opportunities opening up for talent in the automobile industry as top carmakers Maruti Suzuki India, Tata Motors PV and

Singh who joined as chief marketing officer.

"In today's increasingly competitive automotive talent market, compensation corrections are becoming essential to retain critical talent. With new players entering and established OEMs stepping up their expansion plans, aligning benefits with market standards is no longer optional. Such corrections also underline an OEM's willingness to keep its employee value proposition competitive," said Bhavna Kaushik, founder at Abuzz Consulting, a Delhi-based automotive-focused executive search firm.

With Hyundai facing pressure on its market share and looking to recover lost ground with a series of new launches over the next few years, managerial employees executing its strategy have become critical.

Export volumes

In its latest annual report, the company acknowledged its weak performance in FY26, slipping to fourth place in the sales rankings after 16 years as India's second-largest carmaker behind Maruti Suzuki.

"While domestic sales noted a decline due to lower product enhancement activity compared to competitors, our Company noted around 16.4% growth in its export sales volume," Hyundai Motor India said in its management report on its performance in FY26.

Although the company has maintained that it is focused on protecting margins and profitability rather than aggressively chasing the No. 2 spot, the admission suggests that a slower pace of product launches weighed on its performance.

Hyundai has planned more than two dozen launches over the next four years, with a new SUV, Bayon, set to be introduced later this month.

Bollywood's sequel bet faces a test as originals find favour

Lata Jha
lata.j@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Hindi cinema's reliance on sequels and franchise films, including middling box-office performers *Cocktail 2* and *Alpha* stands in contrast to Hollywood's success with new, non-franchise movies such as *Michael*, *Project Hail Mary* and *Obsession* over the past few months.

Theatre owners and experts say the overdose of sequels is evident: rising production and marketing costs have made studios selective, while franchises offer greater predictability in opening weekends. However, sequels with strong buzz are underperforming and the model is generating diminishing returns.

Even though sequels such as *Dhamaal 4* (₹163.80 crore) and *Awarapan 2* (₹146.14 crore) have drawn large audiences, experts say it is important for new brands to come up.

"Hollywood's recent non-franchise successes do not translate directly here because

Sequels with strong buzz are underperforming, pointing to falling returns from the franchise-heavy model

our market is still largely star-driven rather than story-driven," said Kaushik Das, founder and CEO of AAO NXT, an Odia language OTT platform. "A non-star, non-franchise film in India has to clear a very demanding first three-day test, and clearing it depends as much on marketing, release timing and early word-of-mouth as it does on the quality of the film itself."

Original films do break through, but more as an exception than as a pattern, Dass said, adding that theatrical economics in India are built around opening weekends, and opening weekends are



Original films face a tougher first-weekend test because they lack the familiarity of stars, franchises and established brands.

built around familiarity, a star, a known franchise, a recognizable brand.

"An original film has no such head start, so it needs everything else to go right at once: the trailer, the music, the reviews, the timing and the conversation around it. When that alignment happens, the results are magical. When it does not, even a genuinely good film can go unnoticed in week one, and in today's market, week one is often all you get," Das pointed out.

The biggest challenge is that fresh subjects carry all of the risk upfront with none of the built-in insurance a franchise provides, so decision-makers gravitate toward what has worked before.

Ashish Misra, head of commercialization at Cinepolis India, agreed that fresh subjects have to earn audience attention in an increasingly crowded market. However, if a film delivers on its promise, positive word-of-mouth will most definitely extend its theatrical run, he added. "Today, moviegoers rely more on authentic word-of-mouth than pre-release hype, which

gives well-made original films a clear path to succeed. If a film resonates, it continues to attract audiences well beyond its opening weekend, regardless of whether it's a franchise or a fresh IP."

Dhruvandar became the biggest film at release without being part of a franchise, he added. Recent successes such as *Main Wapas Aaunga*, *Saiyara*, *Mahavatar Narsimha*, *Chhaava* and *Kantara* and regional hits like *Laalo* demonstrate that original concepts can deliver exceptional commercial performance, he said.

According to Gautam Dutta, CEO for revenue and operations at PVR Inox Ltd, consumers today have more entertainment choices than ever before, so every visit to the cinema is a conscious decision. They look for stories that offer emotion, scale, originality or spectacle, something that deserves the big screen.

"Original films and franchises are no longer competing with each other; they are complementing each other. A healthy theatrical ecosystem needs both. Franchises create anticipation, while original films bring freshness and often become the franchises of tomorrow," Dutta said.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

SMARTER FINANCIAL DECISIONS START HERE EVERY WEDNESDAY

INTRODUCING

Hindustan Times
YOUR MONEY
PERSONAL FINANCE. MADE SIMPLE.

Better financial decisions begin with better understanding. This weekly series helps you navigate money with greater confidence.



READ EVERY WEDNESDAY



Gujarat Electricity Regulatory Commission

6th Floor, GIFT ONE, Road 5C, Zone 5, GIFT City,
Dist.: Gandhinagar, Gujarat-382050.
(O) 079 23602000, (F) 079 23602054/55
e-mail-gerc@gercin.org Website: www.gercin.org

NOTICE INVITING REQUEST FOR PROPOSALS (RfP) FROM ELIGIBLE CONSULTANT

Gujarat Electricity Regulatory Commission (GERC) has issued a Request for Proposals (RfP) from competent/eligible consulting firms to provide consultancy support in scrutiny, review, approval and monitoring Capital Investment Plan and related matters.

For more details, please visit 'Latest News' at <https://gercin.org/news-category>. The last date for receiving proposal is **26.10.2026**. For future announcement, if any, in this regard, please keep referring to the above website.

Gift City, Gandhinagar
30/09/2026

Sd/-
Ranjeeth Kumar J., IAS
Secretary, GERC



JAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY

Indira Circle, Jawahar Lal Nehru Marg, Jaipur - 302004

No. JDA/EST./ACTT./2026-27/D-1212 Date : 28.09.2026

NOTICE INVITING E-BID NIB No.: DC(Admn.)-04/2026-27

Online Bids are invited for Providing service of Various Types Like Labourers (Supervisor Highly Skilled) security Men (Skilled), Unskilled Labour Services. estimated yearly cost one year of which is Rs. 26.00 Crore. (UBN No.: JDA2627SLOB00334) The last date for applying Bid and making online payment on JDA portal is up to 05:00 PM of 21.10.2026. Details may be seen in the Bidding Document at our office or the State Public Procurement Portal website www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in, www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in and www.jda.rajasthan.gov.in

To participate in the bid, bidder has to be
1. Registered on JDA website www.jda.rajasthan.gov.in, For Participating in the bid, the Bidder has to apply for the bid and pay the Bidding Document Fee, RISL Processing Fee and Bid Security Deposit, Online Only.
2. Registered on e-Procurement Portal of Government of Rajasthan www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in for online e-Bid submission

Deputy Commissioner (Admn.)

Raj.Samwadi/C/26/10997



JAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY

Indira Circle, Jawahar Lal Nehru Marg, Jaipur - 302004

No. F.6(444332)JDA/G.Store/Scanning Work/2026/D-329 Dated : 28-09-2026

NOTICE INVITING BID

NIB No.: JDA/G.Store/18/2026-27

Online Bids are invited For "Scanning Work" up to 21.10.2026 Till 6:00 PM. Estimated cost of Work is **Rs.1,50,00,000/- (One Crore fifty Lacs Only)**. The last date for Applying for Bid and making online payment on JDA portal is 21.10.2026 by 06:00 PM. Details may be seen in the Bidding Document Available on jda.rajasthan.gov.in www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in, www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in. (UBN No.: JDA2627WSRC00338)

To participate in the bid, bidder has to be
1. Registered on JDA website jda.rajasthan.gov.in, For Participating in the bid, the Bidder has to apply for the bid and pay the Bidding Document Fee, RISL Processing Fee and Bid Security Deposit, Online Only.
2. Registered on e-Procurement Portal of Government of Rajasthan www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in for online e-Bid submission

Deputy Commissioner (Store)

Raj.Samwadi/C/26/10999

Have fun with facts on Sundays



Catch the latest column of **HT TWTW** A quiz on the week's development.



Tech CEOs privately questioned Amodei for sounding AI alarm bells

Amrith Ramkumar & Josh Dawsey

WASHINGTON

After agreeing to sign a statement of principles to keep artificial-intelligence models safe Tuesday, AI chief executives surrounded President Trump outside the White House to present the image of a unified industry addressing the public's fears.

Behind the scenes, industry leaders including Jensen Huang of Nvidia had just questioned Anthropic's Dario Amodei about his warnings about the dangers of AI, people familiar with the matter said.

The executives asked Amodei why he was being so extreme in public about the capabilities of AI models and risks they posed following a lunch in the East Room with about two dozen CEOs. Amodei told the other executives that it is important to be honest with the public about model capabilities and not play down risks, some of the people said.

Their conversation occurred with a smaller group of executives and White House aides and advisers who were hashing out the principles in the Roosevelt Room, some of the people said.

Trump and House Speaker Mike Johnson (R., La.) got the top AI companies to agree to the principles at the lunch, but the questioning of Amodei is the latest indication of tensions under the surface between Anthropic and the rest of the industry that could hinder the sector's plan for "self regulation" using model evaluations and internal controls.

Amodei has previously criticized the White House and competitors for playing down safety concerns and warned about AI models carrying out cyberattacks and extreme job losses driven by the technology, making him a target for criticism by many in Washington and Silicon Valley.

Jay Clayton, director of national intelligence, said in a statement that the meeting was "one of the most, if not the most, constructive and collegial industry meetings I have ever seen."

"The focal point was, 'What is best for the American people and globe?' and that focal point drove agreement," said the candidate to be Trump's next AI "czar" coordinating policy across the administration.

On Tuesday, Amodei told reporters "we can win safely" if the industry and administration work together, and Trump praised him for being "great." The duo dined together at the White House Sunday for their first face-to-face meeting.

Anthropic has sought to mend fences with the admin-



Nvidia's CEO was among the execs at White House event who called out Amodei for warning about AI's capabilities.

AFP

istration recently and is gearing up for an initial public offering it hopes will value the company at some \$2 trillion. The company is still reeling from a pair of bruising battles with the administration earlier this year that included a 2-week shutdown of two of its models due to security concerns and being blacklisted by the Pentagon over a dispute regarding how AI is used in the military.

Tuesday's principles were the result of months of discussions over how to prevent AI cyberattacks following the release of Anthropic's Mythos and similar models earlier this year. The administration is testing powerful models before they are released publicly, but recent hacks by AI models have demonstrated the need for stronger reviews when models are being trained and developed, industry executives say.

This summer, Anthropic, OpenAI and Google had coalesced around an approach being considered by the administration for a self-regulatory organization similar to the Financial Industry Regulatory Authority, which oversees brokerage firms.

Huang, Meta Platforms CEO Mark Zuckerberg and SpaceX's Elon Musk told Trump they worried the idea would concentrate too much power in the leading AI companies, so the idea was scrapped, *The Wall Street Journal* previously reported.

That structure also would have involved many of the ideas included in Tuesday's principles such as stronger internal reviews of models during development and external testing.

That highlighted the pressure facing the White House and industry due to public concerns about AI and the data centers powering it.

Zuckerberg in particular played a key role in finaliz-

ing Tuesday's principles, frequently talking to Trump and others in the administration including Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick, who oversees a key government AI testing unit, some of the people said. He has emerged alongside Huang to champion the White House's light-touch approach and push back against calls from researchers at Anthropic and OpenAI to start slowing down model development if needed in coordination with the government.

The push for the dinner began when he and Johnson sat next to each other at the State Dinner with China's Xi Jinping last week and talked about AI policy, some of the people said. Zuckerberg and Huang then tried to coordinate top CEOs while Trump and Johnson organized the lunch to build consensus, these people said. Semafor previously reported on the conversations.

When Amodei brought up his safety concerns during the lunch, Zuckerberg responded that the best way to address them was by following through on the principles as an industry, some of the people said.

Meta has aligned itself with the White House after previously facing criticism from Trump for suspending his social-media accounts following the Jan. 6, 2021, attack on the U.S. Capitol. In Trump's second term, the company settled a lawsuit over the move, rolled back fact-checking protocols, hired Trump-friendly executives and donated to the president's pet causes.

Zuckerberg was smiling and laughing with the president Tuesday while taking questions from the press. "We want to give the American people and our customers confidence that the technology works in the way that we intend," he said.

©2026 DOW JONES & COMPANY, INC.
feedback@livemint.com

The questioning of Amodei is the latest indication of simmering tensions between Anthropic, rest of the industry

company settled a lawsuit over the move, rolled back fact-checking protocols, hired Trump-friendly executives and donated to the president's pet causes.

Zuckerberg was smiling and laughing with the president Tuesday while taking questions from the press. "We want to give the American people and our customers confidence that the technology works in the way that we intend," he said.

©2026 DOW JONES & COMPANY, INC.
feedback@livemint.com

U.S. pressure campaign leaves Iranian tankers stranded in Asian waters

Dozens of vessels are adrift as the U.S. threatens sanctions on countries coming to their aid

Jon Emont
feedback@livemint.com
COLOMBO, SRI LANKA

Some 15 miles off the southwest coast of Sri Lanka, around 20 empty Iranian oil tankers are stranded, drifting with their engines idled as food, fuel and fresh water run short.

They are the most visible consequence of the new pressure campaign by the U.S. to bring Iran to heel. Dozens of Iranian or Iranian-linked tankers that had participated in the shadowy trade of getting sanctioned oil to China have been stuck in the waters near Asian countries like Sri Lanka and Malaysia since July, when the U.S. reimposed its blockade of the Strait of Hormuz.

Then, in recent weeks, U.S. officials have pressured Sri Lanka into blocking local ships from provisioning the tankers and their crews, according to Sri Lankan government documents and companies that provide provisions to those ships.

The Trump administration is pursuing a hardball strategy aimed at forcing Iran into making concessions in the monthslong conflict. In recent days, the U.S.—which slapped Iran with many new sanctions this summer—has warned Iran's trading partners to ditch the country.

Before the war, ships carrying Iranian oil would ferry the crude to international waters off Malaysia, where they transferred it to other tankers that would then transport it to Chinese refineries, an elaborate operation designed to evade U.S. sanctions on Iranian oil.

The tankers would then sail back to Iran, pick up more oil, and do it all again. Some tankers are Iranian. Others sail under other flags but have been sanctioned by the U.S. because of their involvement in such subterfuge.

Now, the blockade has dealt this trade a blow. Iranian ships can't return home. The recent U.S. sanctions blitz means that some Asian ports that once serviced them now refuse them out of fear of U.S. sanctions, leaving the tankers adrift at sea.

The squeeze has also affected container ships bringing goods such as corn and industrial materials to Iran.

On a recent journey to international waters off the coast of Malaysia chartered by the U.S. advocacy group United Against Nuclear Iran, empty, rusting Iranian-linked ships floated high in the water. Many have been anchored there since July.

"When they finish their jobs they park here," said Charlie Brown, a researcher with UANI. "They don't want to go back because of the blockade."

One was the *Elva*, a sanctioned tanker that had loaded up with oil on Iran's Kharg Island and crossed the Strait of Hormuz in June, according to financial data provider LSEG. It has been lingering off Malaysia since discharging the crude to another vessel in a ship-to-ship transfer in August. Sailors on the *Elva* appeared bored. One



Dozens of Iranian or Iranian-linked tankers have been stuck in the waters near Asian countries since July.

REUTERS

started dancing when he saw a passing boat, waving and shaking his hips.

Oil analysts expect that the last of the Iranian oil still waiting to be transferred to buyers will run out in the coming weeks, with payments to Iran to conclude by year's end. "All revenues drop to zero for Iran by December," said Homayoun Falakshahi, head of Crude Oil Analysis at Kpler.

Over the last two months, many of the tankers have left the area off Malaysia for the Indian Ocean and the coast of Sri Lanka, which is closer to Iran and has a history of providing fuel, fresh provisions and repair crews to Iranian ships.

But in August, the U.S. Embassy in the Sri Lankan capital of Colombo informed the government that it was tracking 19 Iranian tankers off the country's western coast and urged officials to tell local port service providers to deny them support or risk U.S. secondary sanctions, according to Sri Lankan government documents

seen by *The Wall Street Journal*. Around this time, many of the Iranian vessels pulled away from Sri Lanka's territorial waters, with many drifting deeper into the Indian Ocean, their engines idled to conserve fuel, according to ship-tracking data and Sri Lankan maritime businesses.

When, in early September, two Iranian-flagged container vessels anchored in the port limits of Colombo, Sri Lanka's port authority stated in a letter seen by the *Journal* that it wasn't "prudent to provide services to Iranian-flagged" vessels because of the risk of U.S. sanctions.

In mid-September, the U.S. Embassy in Colombo conducted a three-day training session with more than 40 Sri Lankan officials, laying out the risk of U.S. penalties if shipping agents, fuel providers and other service companies "knowingly or unknowingly" support sanctioned vessels.

"Sri Lanka sits at a strategic crossroads for global commerce, bringing both tremendous opportunity and the need for vigilance," U.S. Ambassador to Sri Lanka Eric Meyer said in a September statement. The U.S. was taking decisive action to stamp out sanctions evasion by "sharing U.S. expertise with our Sri Lankan partners."

The State Department said that the U.S. will "continue to disrupt, expose, and dismantle" Iran's illicit oil trade, and called on the international community to hold Iran accountable. The State Department didn't reply to a separate request for comment on the conditions facing the crews of the Iranian-linked vessels.

Dubai-based shipping agents for the tankers have pleaded with businesses in Sri Lanka to send out fresh food and fuel. But representatives of Sri Lankan shipping companies say it has become difficult to secure approval from port authorities to provide any services for Iranian vessels.

The owner of a Sri Lankan shipping repair company that dispatched a team to an Iranian ship just before the onset of the new restrictions found that provisions on the tanker were dwindling. While repair crews are normally fed on board and can wash there, the tanker's crew told them to bring their own food and warned them that they couldn't wash because the vessel needed to conserve fresh water, according to the company official.

Another Sri Lankan shipper said he has received desperate calls for food and provisions from agents of the tankers, but Sri Lankan authorities weren't approving supply visits to Iranian ships.

Thushara Rodrigo, a spokesman for Sri Lanka's foreign ministry, acknowledged the risk that sanctioned ships might run out of food, fuel and water. He said that if ships require emergency

provisions, private companies could be reluctant to supply the tankers and risk sanctions.

Other Iran-linked vessels have ventured to waters near India and China. Some of those that have remained in the familiar waters near Malaysia have moved north from an area known as the Eastern Outer Port Limits, where ship-to-ship transfers of Iranian oil have normally taken place. UANI analysts say this could be the result of stepped-up Malaysian enforcement activity. A Malaysian coast-guard official didn't respond to a request for comment.

On a recent trip, a pair of small local sampan vessels pulled up to the *Parnia*, an Iranian cargo ship idling off the coast of southeastern Malaysia. *The Parnia* had been stranded there since July when it returned from China

stacked with containers, according to ship-tracking data. The sailors onboard the sampans are known to go from ship to ship, selling basic supplies like cigarettes and beer.

Iranian ships were guarded when they were contacted by radio. In response to an inquiry about whether there was enough food onboard, one ship responded in terse Farsi: "Do not worry about our food."

Advocates of a tougher policy against Iran say that targeting those that provision the ships could raise the cost—and risk—of owning and servicing vessels that carry Iranian oil and other goods, making it difficult to carry out Iran's shadow oil trade. In August, the U.S. sanctioned a network of companies that provided fuel to Iranian ships.

"A vessel that is sitting and not carrying oil is just a hole in the budget," said Mark Wallace, UANI's CEO, who has called for tougher U.S. sanctions against Malaysian groups that supply the ships.

©2026 DOW JONES & COMPANY, INC.

Oil analysts expect the last of the Iranian oil still waiting to be transferred to buyers to run out in coming weeks

Apple's biggest battleground for foldable phones is China

Hannah Miao
feedback@livemint.com
BEIJING

Demand for some foldable phones in China is surging, even before Apple's new foldable iPhone Duo arrives.

That suggests an opportunity for Apple to expand what has been a niche category—if it can overcome competition from Chinese brands.

Winning over China is key to Apple's fortunes. The country makes up more than a third of global folding smartphone sales and is the largest single market for foldables, according to research firm Counterpoint Research.

Chinese company Huawei is currently the market leader in

China, both for foldables and smartphones generally. Huawei released its first folding smartphone in 2019. Other Chinese brands, including Xiaomi, Vivo, Oppo and Honor, have been selling foldables for years.

After Apple announced its first foldable iPhone in early September, sales during the following four days of Huawei's Pura X Max—which has similar

dimensions to the Duo—grew about 77% from the same period a week earlier, according to Huawei. More than 1.4 million units of the Pura X Max have been sold since its release in April, according to Huawei.

Xiaomi's 18 Fold, another passport-size folding phone, notched record first-week

sales for the company's foldables after its release in early September, a representative said.

Richard Yu, chairman of Huawei's consumer business, said the company has invested heavily to make breakthroughs in screen reliability and camera quality for its foldables.

"I know how hard-earned these achievements were, which is why we are a leader in this business," said Yu.

Apple didn't respond to a request for comment.

Foldables are still a relatively niche product, making up roughly 4% of smartphone sales in China and about 2% globally, according to Counterpoint. They can be fragile, and it is harder to put a good camera on a folding smartphone.

Still, brands hope foldables



Huawei and other Chinese competitors reported higher demand for foldables after announcement of iPhone Duo.

REUTERS

can attract higher-end customers. Huawei's Pura X Max starts at the equivalent of more than \$1,600. It also has been selling trifolding smartphones that unfurl twice, like a pamphlet. Huawei's second-generation trifold, called the Mate

XT2, released in early September, starts at nearly \$3,000.

The iPhone Duo starts at \$1,999 in the U.S. and 15,999 yuan in China, equivalent to nearly \$2,400. Apple has said consumers in the U.S., China and many other countries will

be able to preorder the iPhone Duo on Oct. 16, and it will be available a week later.

Fans of foldables often use the devices to work on the go. The larger screens help with multitasking and reviewing documents.

Wang Rui, an 18-year-old college student in Beijing, said he was considering buying the Mate XT2 and went to Huawei's flagship store in Beijing to check it out. He also visited

Apple's store across the street in hopes of testing the Duo, but it wasn't on display yet. He said he has previously used foldable phones made by Oppo and Vivo.

"Like cutting-edge technology," said Wang, pulling up

Foldables are still a relatively niche product, making up roughly 4% of smartphone sales in China and about 2% globally

stock-market data on the Mate XT2's 10.2-inch screen. "As of now, Apple hasn't reached this level yet."

Despite Apple's late entry into the market, Counterpoint projects the company will sell up to six million foldable iPhones this year and take a quarter of the global foldables market. The firm predicts Apple will beat out Huawei's 22% global market share.

Foldable pioneer Samsung, which has only a small presence in China, is expected to maintain its lead with a 38% global share in foldables, according to Counterpoint.

Huawei is effectively barred from selling its products in the U.S. It has been blacklisted by

NEWS
NUMBERS

2.2%

THE GROWTH rate of the US economy in April-June, driven by consumer spending and business investment, but decelerating from a 2.5% pace in the first quarter.

₹0.115

THE PER-MESSAGE fee Meta is charging Indian businesses for WhatsApp service messages, once their monthly free quota of 1,000 messages is exhausted.

\$2.89 tn

THE ESTIMATED total cost of US wars in Iraq and Syria by 2050, including future veteran care, per Brown University, as the US completes its withdrawal from Iraq.

29,582

THE NUMBER of units sold in the 205-340cc motorcycle segment in August, marking a 72.03% year-on-year growth, led by the TVS Ronin 225.

74%

THE PERCENTAGE of India's high-net-worth entrepreneurs intending to relocate overseas or obtain another residency, according to an HSBC report.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Rural distress dents tractor sales in Sep

India's weakest monsoon in over a decade dented rural spending in September and weighed on tractor sales, data showed on Thursday, while urban demand supported sales of passenger vehicles.

The June-September monsoon was 12.6% below normal this year, fuelling concerns over crop yields, rural demand and food inflation in Asia's No.3 economy.

Mahindra & Mahindra, India's largest tractor maker, reported a 21% drop in tractor sales during the month, while smaller rival Escorts Kubota posted a 16.7% decline.

"Lower farm incomes and, as a result, rising rural indebtedness hurt purchasing power and demand for consumer goods and services, while supply shortages can push up food prices and stoke inflationary pressures," said Rohit Azad, an economics professor at Delhi's Jawaharlal Nehru University.

REUTERS



Tewolde Gebremariam is the second foreign CEO and MD to head the loss-making airline.

Gebremariam takes charge at Air India

Tewolde Gebremariam formally assumed charge as chief executive officer (CEO) and managing director (MD) of Air India on Thursday.

Gebremariam, whose appointment was announced on 5 August, received security clearance this week.

An Ethiopian, Gebremariam is taking over at a time when the airline is working on its ambitious expansion plans amid multiple external headwinds. He is the second foreign CEO and MD to head loss-making Air India.

During a town hall with the staff on Monday, Gebremariam said cost discipline must become part of Air India's culture and identified sustainable profitability, safety and operational reliability as key priorities for the airline. He also plans to introduce programmes that reward employees for ideas that deliver measurable cost savings and improve operational efficiency.

PTI

ATF, commercial LPG prices raised

Aviation turbine fuel (ATF) prices were raised by a steep ₹16 per litre to ₹137 from Thursday, while the price of commercial LPG was increased by ₹62.50 per 19-kg cylinder in step with firming international benchmarks, according to state-owned oil companies.

The revision comes after ATF prices were raised by ₹6.28 per litre in September, following a ₹5 per litre increase in August. ATF accounts for up to 40% of operating costs for airlines.

Commercial LPG prices were raised by ₹9.50 per 19-kg cylinder in September, following two consecutive monthly reductions of ₹192 in August and ₹183.50 in July. The cuts came after commercial LPG prices had surged to a record high in June amid disruptions to global energy supplies and elevated international prices.

The latest changes are based on movements in international benchmark prices and the rupee-dollar exchange rate.

PTI

Adani Green BESS capacity at 6.6 GWh

Adani Green Energy Ltd has expanded its operational battery energy storage system (BESS) capacity to 6.63 GWh, which can store enough clean energy to power around two million homes a day. With this, the company has achieved almost 70% of its target for fiscal year 2027 (FY27).

The 6.63 GWh BESS supports peak electricity demand of cities like Nagpur, Patna or Visakhapatnam for several hours. The company now accounts for more than 50% of India's operational BESS capacity of about 12.6 GWh, Adani Green said in a statement on Thursday.

The firm said it has achieved the 6.63 GWh milestone within 14 months of commencing on-site BESS construction at Khavda, and is on track to add over 10 GWh of BESS capacity in FY27. As of June, Adani Green had 3.55 GWh of operational BESS capacity. The company is targeting 50 GWh of storage capacity over the next five years.

PTI

Mayank Khanduja joins Bessemer Venture Partners

Bessemer Venture Partners has appointed Mayank Khanduja as partner in its India practice. He will focus on early-stage investments, partnering with founders from their first institutional round onwards.

Khanduja's previous stints include Elevation Capital and McKinsey, and he brings 15 years of venture investing experience, across consumer tech, gaming, healthcare, artificial intelligence (AI) and deeptech. He has backed companies including ShareChat, NoBroker, PlaySimple Games, Jeh Aerospace, MOC Cancer Care, Loop Health, Atlys, Seekho, General Autonomy and PierSight.

Bessemer has been active in India for the two decades. It recently announced the raise of \$5.75 billion of capital globally to back founders from seed through growth in the AI era.

PRIYAMVADA C

NSE gets Sebi nod to launch corporate bond index futures

The National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) on Thursday said it received a no-objection certificate from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) to introduce futures contracts on a corporate bond index.

The proposed product will give market participants an exchange-traded instrument to manage corporate bond market risk and help develop India's corporate bond derivatives ecosystem, NSE said in a statement.

Corporate bond index futures are expected to offer an additional avenue for risk management, portfolio hedging and price discovery, while supporting market-making by enabling participants to manage risks arising from their corporate bond portfolios.

The launch of the product, however, is subject to requisite approval from the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), the NSE statement noted.

REUTERS

NoBroker targets 1st profit with AI aid

Startup NoBroker is using artificial intelligence (AI) to cut tasks previously handled by people, putting the Indian real estate company closer to profitability.

The online platform, which offers rentals, property sales and services like home loans, movers, and interior designing, has harnessed AI for tasks such as sales and customer service, co-founder and chief technology officer Akhil Gupta said. It now envisages profit in about 10 months—its first since its founding more than a decade ago—paving the way for a stock market debut, he said. "We avoided hiring hundreds of personnel," Gupta said in an interview. "The impact on our cost structure is massive."

NoBroker has deployed 65 distinct AI agents across its divisions to take care of user queries, qualify leads, reactivate customers and schedule interactions, Gupta said. About 30% of its call volume is now handled without human intervention.

BLOOMBERG

Govt to intervene as private refiners cap diesel sales

No oil marketing company is permitted to restrict sales, says petroleum secretary

Rituraj Baruah
rituraj.baruah@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

The Centre will raise the issue of recent diesel sales restrictions with private refiners and ask them to roll back the move, said Neeraj Mittal, secretary, Union ministry of petroleum and natural gas. Addressing reporters on Thursday, Mittal said no oil marketing company (OMC) is permitted to restrict fuel sales.

Private operators Jio-bp and Nayara Energy have both capped diesel sales. *Mint* first reported that Jio-bp reinstated a limit of 50 litres per transaction. *Bloomberg* recently reported that Nayara has similarly capped diesel sales at 70-200 litres per transaction.

Responding to a question on the restrictions, the secretary said: "Nobody is allowed to put a cap on sales. So, if they are putting a cap on sale, we will take it up. We will tell them that it is not acceptable, it is not done. In the past also, letters have been issued. So, the same thing applies even today."

Union petroleum and natural gas minister Hardeep Singh Puri said the government is "always in touch with" private fuel retailers.

Reliance Industries Ltd-backed Jio-bp, which accounts for a fifth of India's roughly 10,000 private fuel retail pumps, had previously restricted diesel sales and imposed a diesel procurement quota for its pumps in April. India has a total of around 100,000 fuel pumps. Rosneft-backed Nayara Energy has more than 7,000 petrol



REUTERS

pumps in the country.

"Nayara Energy continues to maintain fuel supply across its nationwide dealer retail network and ensure seamless access to fuel for its customers. We remain committed to serving the Indian market and meeting the demand for fuel across the length and breadth of the country," Nayara Energy said in response to an email query from *Mint*. Queries emailed to Jio-bp on Thursday evening remained unanswered at presstime.

Jio-bp and Nayara Energy are key exporters of petroleum products. A recent report by Finnish think tank Centre for Research on Energy and the Clean Air said Russia imported a record 172,000 tonnes of petroleum products in August, with most of the supplies coming from India. It noted that supplies from Nayara's Vadinar refinery comprised about 70% of Russia's imports.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

UPI volumes, value fall in Sep after MDR announced

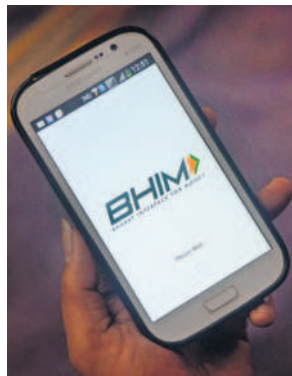
FROM PAGE 1

Reeju Datta, co-founder of payments gateway Cashfree Payments, said UPI use is typically higher in the first half as people get salaries and pay bills and installments. While September saw a sharper fall in the second half than in earlier months, the average daily transaction volume for the month was the highest ever at 802 million, with an average daily value of ₹97,013 crore.

Between January and August 2026, the daily transaction count in the second half was 3-5% lower than in the first, said Datta. The decline was 6% in September. The decline in daily value of UPI payments in the second half, by comparison, was in 10-19% range during January-August; in September, it was 17%.

Some industry experts describe the development as a knee-jerk reaction, given that MDR will take effect only from 15 October. "We are seeing more conversations around the cost of higher-value UPI transactions, particularly from merchants with tighter margins," said Kunal Jhunjhunwala, founder of airpay, adding there could be some moderation in October, especially among high-value merchants.

The announcement has prompted merchants to con-



The MDR was announced on 15 September.

MINT

sider the cost of accepting higher-value UPI payments even before the new structure takes effect. There is also some confusion about which transactions will actually attract MDR," said Jhunjhunwala. As merchants gain more clarity on rules and how they apply to them, some of this initial concern may subside, he added.

October may also show a different trend. "September suggests some caution in the market, but October may be different as the new MDR structure takes effect midway through the month," Jhunjhunwala said, adding that some categories may be hit, with merchants with a larger share of over ₹2,000 transactions likely more affected.

The finance ministry has reintroduced a 0.4% MDR on

person-to-merchant (P2M) UPI transactions of above ₹2,000, while capping the total fees at ₹300. Person-to-person (P2P) transactions, utility-bill payments, auto-debit transactions and mutual-fund subscriptions, as well as payments to small merchants receiving up to ₹1 lakh per month through UPI QR codes, have been exempt.

At an event on 24 September, NPCI chief executive Dilip Asbe said any change causes disruption but that overall transaction volumes are expected to remain steady. However, he acknowledged that reintroducing MDR after six years without charges had been "difficult" and could "create some pain", attributing the pushback from ecosystem players to misinformation on the structure of MDR charges.

"Any post-15 October dip must be evaluated in context, as UPI volumes and value naturally contract during the second half of every month. If a dip exceeds the historical 3-5% volume or 10-19% value range, it would warrant concern; otherwise, it reflects standard fluctuations," Cashfree Payments' Datta said.

Festival-season spending may support UPI transactions even after 15 October, he said.

For an extended version of the story, go to [livemint.com](#)

FROM PAGE 1

per kilometre basis, depending on contracts that run for over a decade. Electric bus operators typically procure buses from manufacturers and tie up with firms that help develop the infrastructure required to run them.

The pricing in the tender was very aggressive, "with the difference between the lowest and the second-lowest bidder being around 10% in many cases," one of the executives cited above said.

The order will allow JSW to diversify beyond captive demand for electric buses, with the company also targeting staff buses for its plants and offices as a major demand driver. In April, its foray was marked by registering 25 buses for use at a group steel plant.

JSW group's auto businesses, including CV and passenger vehicles, are privately held.

The group participated in the tender with its own fleet operator, JSW Eco Mobility, indicating it won't only make the buses but also operate them for over 10 years.

"The entry of an established industry conglomerate like JSW Group is a positive development considering their potential to make big-ticket investments. This can be seen as a progression in their foray into India's EV manufacturing space," said Shyamasis Das, who heads the electric-mobility research vertical at New Delhi-based think tank Centre for



The order will give a boost to Sajjan Jindal-owned JSW Group.

MINT

Social and Economic Progress. JSW has kicked off its electric-bus push with an annual capacity of 10,000 units at its 90-acre unit in Chhatrapati Sambhaji Nagar, launching its buses under the Ampstar brand.

Initially planned for 3,604 e-buses, the government tender was expanded to 4,054 buses to include demand from Haryana. Other winners include PMI, which bagged 1,248 buses; clean urban transport firm Sai Green Project, which won 1,236 buses; and Eka Mobility, which won 270 buses. Software firm Inventive Software Solutions Pvt. Ltd. won 100 buses.

Eka Mobility confirmed the development in an email. JSW declined to comment. Emails to PMI, Sai Green and Inventive Software Solutions remained unan-

swered. Central government tendering agency Convergence Energy Services Ltd (CESL) did not respond to emailed queries.

The PM-eBus Sewa scheme is part of the government's push to electrify mobility and reduce dependence on imported crude oil. The shift has gained momentum as the government increasingly directs subsidies towards electric buses and trucks.

India recorded 5,356 electric bus sales in FY26, a 37% jump from the previous fiscal, as per data from the government's Vahan registration portal. India is world's third largest e-bus market by sales, according to the International Energy Agency.

These sales are propelled by the Centre's PM-eDrive and PM-eBus Sewa schemes, which together support rollout of electric bus fleets across over 100 cities in India. Under the PM E-Drive scheme, government supports the deployment of more than 14,000 e-buses across nine major cities. The PM-eBus Sewa scheme provides operational support of ₹24 per km for 12-metre buses.

Legacy companies such as Tata Motors and Ashok Leyland have not emerged as major winners in these government tenders, which have seen newer players such as Eka Mobility and PMI Electro dominate with about two-thirds of the share in more than 20,000 electric buses tendered in the past one year.

[ayaan.kartik@livemint.com](#)



The lender's exposure to the sector is a little over 2% of its corporate loan book.

REUTERS

Axis Bank to double data centre loans

Axis Bank Ltd plans to double its exposure to data centres over the next three years, a top executive said, as the nation's artificial intelligence (AI) push spurs investment in digital infrastructure.

India's third-largest private sector lender by assets has financed about a dozen data centre clients and its exposure to the sector is a little over 2% of its corporate loan book, according to Vijay Mulbagal, group head of wholesale banking coverage. That would amount to more than ₹8,688 crore (\$907 million), based on the bank's first-quarter earnings data.

"Data-related investments in India are growing," Mulbagal said in an interview. "The growth is strong and companies have to resort to borrowings apart from bringing in equity to be able to meet their ambition of larger capacities."

Beyond India, Axis has also approached data centre firms based in Singapore about potential financing opportunities, Mulbagal said.

India's AI and data centre push is opening up a new pool of lending opportunities for banks as developers turn to debt alongside equity to fund capital-intensive projects.

REUTERS



T20: WHEN CLUB OR COUNTRY TURNS INTO A GOOGLY

The original fault lines was club or country. It's increasingly becoming club in home country or club in foreign country.

howindialives.com
feedback@livemint.com

It's hard to keep English cricketer Ben Stokes out of the game. Or, the news. Three months after his shock retirement from international cricket, Stokes is at the forefront of a debate that has happened before—and will happen again, and again, in the years to come. In a cricketing landscape that is seeing the march of club cricket dust out and redraw all kinds of boundaries, Stokes is the current lightning rod of the tradeoff between club and country, self-interest and national interest.

After walking away from international cricket, the 35-year-old is keen to hit the relatively more lucrative stops of T20 club cricket. First up is Australia, in December and January. Here, Stokes has signed a contract worth, at current exchange rates, reportedly about ₹3.3 crore for 10-13 matches. This is about a third of what he is believed to have last made playing for England round the year, across many countries.

Next up, according to *The Guardian*, Stokes is lining up T20 leagues in Pakistan and the US. But the English cricket board might not give him a no-objection certificate (NOC). Stokes needs this NOC as he is contracted to an English county, Durham. The Pakistan and US leagues operate in a window that overlaps with the English domestic season, and the board doesn't want to let go off a prime draw like Stokes. It fears that giving Stokes an NOC would set a precedent—more English players will selectively abandon English county cricket for global T20 leagues that effectively pay more.

The NOC is English cricket's power play, a lever to control its players. But with a marquee name like Stokes, it can't be as blunt as the Indian board, which simply doesn't allow Indian players to play in other T20 leagues till they have retired from the national team and the Indian Premier League (IPL). The English cricket board is yet to decide on Stokes' participation in the other T20 leagues.

The last word on the Australian cricket board's plan to bite the bullet and start privatizing teams in its T20 franchise league remains. If it goes through with that plan, announced last month, it would be the last of the four major cricket countries to do so, the other three being India, Australia and England. That plan has divided stakeholders, resulting in the resignation of the Cricket Australia (CA) chair on 28 September.

The string that joins these disparate conflicts, stances and responses is the state of flux cricket finds itself in. Private money is chasing club-based T20 cricket. The Indian cricketing board acted first, with the IPL. The past three years have seen other boards take to private capital, albeit reluctantly, to stay relevant. Their response is opening many fault lines—between boards of different countries, between a board and its state affiliates, between a board and its players.

BOARD VS BOARD

National cricket boards, to whom players are affiliated, sit atop the superstructure of their T20 leagues. For all their independence, there is a hierarchy even among them. The Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) controls Indian cricket, but it also wields a sizeable influence on world cricket. In 2008, it was the first to embrace club-based T20 leagues, with the IPL. Australia followed in 2011, with the Big Bash League (BBL).

But the difference in scale is massive. A

If players could choose leagues and followed the money, they could well opt for leagues other than that of their own country.

bin. Further, it generated a net surplus that was about 75 times the other three boards combined.

Cricket Australia can do little about its financial gap with the BCCI, or of the BBL with the IPL. But increasingly, in the T20 league context, it is compelled to think about its distance to England and South Africa. That's because these two countries have privatized teams in their short-format leagues—South Africa in 2023 and England in 2025. That privatization led to a windfall for the boards, with the English one receiving about 520 million pounds (about ₹5,700 crore).

Player salaries increased. In The Hundred, the budget for each men's team

good measure is the broadcasting deal, the main revenue component of T20 franchise leagues. The current media deal for just the IPL fetches the BCCI about ₹9,678 crore per year. The current annual CA deal for the Big Bash League, as well as for all international matches played in Australia, is ₹1,470 crore.

That naturally influences player salaries. For the 2026 season, each IPL team had a total player budget of ₹146 crore, against about ₹21 crore in the BBL. Similar differentials exist between the IPL and The Hundred (a 100-ball format) in England and the SA20 in South Africa.

This also gets reflected in the financial position of the respective cricket boards—and shapes their choices. The Indian board is a profit machine, the other three boards live hand to mouth. In 2024-25, the BCCI's revenues amounted to 1.7 times that of the boards of England, Australia and South Africa combined.

Cricket Australia can do little about its financial gap with the BCCI, or of the BBL with the IPL. But increasingly, in the T20 league context, it is compelled to think about its distance to England and South Africa. That's because these two countries have privatized teams in their short-format leagues—South Africa in 2023 and England in 2025. That privatization led to a windfall for the boards, with the English one receiving about 520 million pounds (about ₹5,700 crore).

Player salaries increased. In The Hundred, the budget for each men's team

increased from 1 million pounds in 2023 to 2.05 million pounds (about ₹26 crore) in 2026. Similarly, SA20 had a team budget of ₹21 crore in 2025—almost the same as in the BBL.

In a podcast interview earlier this year, Australian cricket captain Pat Cummins spoke about the "tension point" among Australian players in turning down the opportunity to play in The Hundred and instead playing two tests against Bangladesh in August 2026.

If players could choose leagues and followed the money, they could well opt for leagues other than that of their own country. Cummins himself has not played in the BBL since 2019, but has played in five seasons in the IPL thereafter. One reason is the BBL season runs almost concurrently with Australia's home season for test matches.

Cummins earns about \$AUS 3 million (about ₹20 crore) from CA. This is part of the current deal, where CA shares about 27.5% of its revenues with Australian players contracted at various levels. But there's unrest brewing in a shifting cricketing landscape. The feeling among Australian players is they could be earning more, especially as they are seeing peers from South Africa and England, or even full free agents, do so. This can lead to Australian players making choices that are awkward for CA.

BOARD VS STATE AFFILIATES

In this backdrop, CA said it would privatize one BBL team. That process began in September, with a call for expressions of interest to buy 100% in the Melbourne Renegades. As in England and South Africa, such a move would give CA more funds to distribute among players and inject into the sport. A private owner could also lift the team's finances and profile. But not every stakeholder is on board.

In India, cricket governance is centralized, and state associations toe the BCCI line. In Australia, state associations have a voice. Two of the six state associations, New South Wales and Queensland, have rejected privatization. New South Wales was also the home association of CA chair Mike Baird, who resigned on 28 September. These two state associations argue that private owners will prioritize profits over re-investing into local pathways and community cricket. While they recognize the need for more finances, they feel this can be raised even in the current structure.

Unlike Australia, England had an easier time with their county affiliates. In The Hundred, the English board sold 49% of the eight teams to private investors via a bidding process. That resulted in a combined valuation of the eight teams of about £975 million (about ₹10,700 crore)—about 32% less than what just one team in the IPL, Rajasthan Royals, was sold for this May. It transferred the remaining 51% to the eight counties, some of whom sold additional stakes.

South Africa is structured along the



₹9,678 CRORE

Annual broadcasting revenue earned by the Board of Control for Cricket in India just from Indian Premier League matches.

₹1,470 CRORE

Cricket Australia's yearly take from the Big Bash League and international matches played in Australia.

₹146 CRORE

The total player budget of each IPL team for the 2026 season, against about ₹21 crore in the BBL.

same lines as the IPL, with a 100% franchise model for its six teams. This approach transferred the financial risk to private backers while securing upfront expansion fees.

This financial strengthening of the English and South African cricket boards in this manner plays into the BCCI's hands. All six teams in SA20, and four of the eight teams in The Hundred, trace their ownership to IPL teams. Given the leverage the BCCI has over them in the IPL, it also implicitly gives the BCCI some influence over other leagues, especially in the context of how the leagues evolve and compete against each other.

BOARDS VS PLAYERS

In all this churn, the BCCI is sitting pretty. Because of India's vast consumer market, cricket's appeal and media landscape, the BCCI does not need external capital to keep the IPL thriving. It uses that unfettered power in ways that can be seen as self-serving at best and monopolistic at worst.

Take player participation. It does not allow Indian male players from participating in overseas T20 leagues till they retire from international cricket and the IPL. This May, 35-year-old Vijay Shankar did just that, prompting the BCCI to weigh changes. At the same time, with its considerable financial and soft power, the BCCI draws overseas players. Some other countries have player associations, notably England and Australia, and they have negotiated concessions from their boards to play in the IPL.

Cricketers today are earning signifi-

Global impact

BCCI wields a sizeable influence on world cricket

2024-25 financials (in ₹ crore)

	Total income	Net profit
Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI)	11,055	4,014
England and Wales Cricket Board	3,436	16
Cricket Australia	2,508	-74
Cricket South Africa	644	110

All four boards have different financial years: India from April to March, England from February to January, South Africa from May to April, and Australia from July to June. Figures for other boards converted to Rs crore at the average exchange rate for the period.

Source: Annual reports of respective boards

Wage-to-revenue ratio in 2024-25 (%)

Ligue 1 (France)	80
Serie A (Italy)	66
EPL (England)	65
LaLiga (Spain)	60
Bundesliga (Germany)	54
Royal Challengers Bengaluru (IPL)	22
Mumbai Indians (IPL)	21

Source: Deloitte Annual Review of Football Finance 2026; annual reports

mint

MANU CHOUDHARY/MINT



Shubman Gill earned ₹11.5 crore over 71 match days playing for India in 2025 and ₹17.6 crore from the IPL's Gujarat Titans over 15 playing days.

P11



Tech wealth fuelled Bengaluru's luxury home boom. What now?

The equation is changing amid AI-led job uncertainty, lower stock-market gains and fewer Esop liquidity events

Ananya Grover
ananya.grover@livemint.com
MUMBAI

When Shreyas Nair, 33, sold a company he built which helped other startups scale from zero to \$10 million in revenue, the proceeds left him heavily concentrated in equity. In 2025, he decided to put some of that wealth into an under-construction project in East Bengaluru with handover expected in March 2027.

The purchase followed the boom between 2021 and 2024, when rising technology stocks, salary increases and startup liquidity events delivered windfalls for some employees in the technology sector. Many used this money to convert equity-linked savings into tangible apartments in Bengaluru, a major technology and startup centre in India.

The timing proved favourable as the housing market recovered from the pandemic led slowdown after 2021 and home loan rates near historic lows improved affordability. According to Anarock Research & Advisory, the city's average quoted base selling price rose about 60%, from ₹5,217 per sq ft in 2021 to ₹8,380 per sq ft at the end of 2024.

However, that dynamic is shifting. With property prices already stretched, mounting AI-related job uncertainty, cooler stock market returns, and a drop in employee stock option (Esop) liquidity events, does this real estate strategy still hold up?

How the 2021-24 cycle worked
One factor that boosted the appeal of residential units was the opportunity to reinvest eligible capital gains into a home under Section 86 (previously section 54F) of the Income Tax Act subject to certain conditions. This option was particularly relevant for those who monetized shares, Esops or other capital assets, according to Sougata Basu, founder of CashRich.

The provision allows an exemption on eligible long-term capital gains when the net sale proceeds from specified assets are invested in a residential property in India, subject to conditions. Effective April 2024, the maximum investment eligible for calculating this exemption has been capped at ₹10 crore.

"In 2021, technology salaries, venture capital funding and Esop liquidity all peaked together. That provision made luxury apartments a common destination for exit proceeds," Basu said. Post-pandemic, pent-up housing demand and low interest rates converged with record compensation in tech. Strong demand for talent drove up salaries, while a wave of startup buybacks, secondary sales, acquisitions, and listings allowed employees to cash out Esops. In 2021, Indian tech startups raised a record \$38.3 billion, according to data from Tracxn.

Beyond unlisted startups, the post-

When tech wealth finds a home

Rising salaries, RSUs and startup liquidity once helped fuel Bengaluru's premium housing boom. As tech wealth becomes less predictable, the property equation may change.

How tech professionals are funding Bengaluru homes

SHREYAS NAIR (33)
Chief marketing officer, Ideas2IT Technologies



Wealth event/source:
Startup exit, equity-heavy wealth

Property strategy:
Under-construction project bought on loan. Expects prices to rise from ₹9,500 per sq ft to ₹15,000-18,000 per sq ft, given the location.

“Concerns around layoffs could weigh on big-ticket purchases but I am comfortable being a little risk-forward.”

ANKITA GHOSH (29)
Systems development engineer, Google



Wealth event/source:
Rising value of RSUs and salary hike

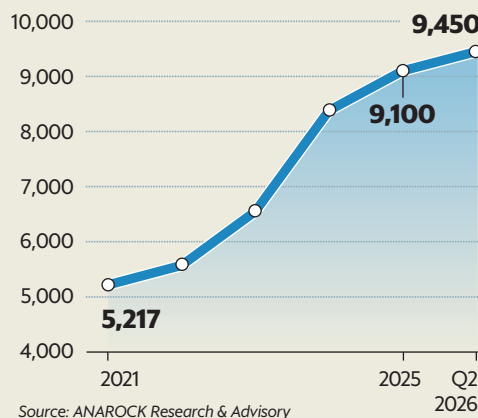
Property strategy:
Under-construction apartment on loan for self-use and potential rental income if she lets it out.

“Took some risk but I am well backed up with enough corpus in the form of RSUs as I joined before the boom occurred and they are still multiplying.”

RSUs: Restricted stock units; ESOP: Employee stock option plan

Price trend in Bengaluru since 2021

Average base selling price per sq. ft. (in ₹)



Source: ANAROCK Research & Advisory



What has changed?

2021-24	Now
Strong salary growth in tech sector	AI-led job uncertainty
Equity market gains	More volatile returns
Startup funding and liquidity	More selective funding
Rising property prices	Price growth moderating
ESOP liquidity events	Liquidity timing less predictable

mint

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

pandemic rally in listed tech stocks sharply boosted the value of restricted stock units (RSUs), particularly for employees at global technology giants.

Unlike Esops, which give employees the option to purchase shares at a set price, RSUs are actual shares granted outright that vest over time, meaning their payout rises directly with the company's stock price.

For employees catching all these tailwinds at once, the math was simple: higher salaries covered larger home loans, surging RSUs swelled net worth, startup equity turned into liquid cash, and Bengaluru real estate kept appreciating.

Why the equation is changing

However, Basu doubts these ideal conditions will recur anytime soon, noting that AI is set to commoditize routine coding and weigh on tech pay over the coming years. He breaks luxury-home buyers into three key

groups facing distinct headwinds: investors turning financial gains into physical real estate; NRIs navigating shifting tax rules and currency swings; and tech employees whose equity-heavy pay packages are far less predictable than fixed salaries.

"Salaried employees face 20-25-year loan commitments that do not pause if a job does. Structural rental yields of 2-3% amount to a negative carry once loan costs are factored in, and price appreciation depends entirely on the broader economic cycle," he said.

Property prices are still rising, but at a slower pace. Anarock data shows that the average quoted base selling price increased from ₹8,380 per sq ft in 2024 to ₹9,100 in 2025, or nearly 9%. Growth then slowed to about 3.8% between 2025 and Q2 2026, when prices reached ₹9,450 per sq ft.

Prashant Thakur, executive director and head of research & advisory at Anarock Group, said AI has

made buyers more cautious in the short term, but believes Bengaluru's housing demand has broader support from its growing global capability centres (GCC) ecosystem, high-value technology and non-IT functions, and rental demand.

People are still buying

Despite these risks, demand for premium homes remains strong. Homes priced above ₹1.5 crore accounted for 62% of Bengaluru's residential sales in the first half of 2026, compared with 11% in 2022, according to Anarock. Young professionals in AI, semiconductors and well-funded startups are an emerging source of this demand.

Praveer Shrivastava, associate director, residential, Prestige Group, said many buyers in their late 20s and early 30s are using RSU vesting, Esop liquidity events and salary hikes to make their first premium home purchase,

typically in the ₹2-5 crore range in north and east Bengaluru.

That buyers continue to enter the market, even as the optimal window narrows, points to motivations beyond pure market analysis. As Lovaii Navlakh, managing director and CEO of International Money Matters, puts it: each homebuyer approaches the decision through their own lens, shaped by personal experience, external advice, deep-seated conviction, or at times, sheer obstinacy.

Hidden concentration

For employees whose income and wealth are already tied to technology, buying a Bengaluru property may not provide as much diversification as it seems to. Sudden liquidity from RSUs, bonuses, or pay hikes often prompts clients to lock financial gains into tangible assets like real estate, according to Rohit Suri, CEO of the UHNI business at Ionic Wealth.

But selling technology shares and putting a large portion of the proceeds into a Bengaluru flat could be a case of replacing one type of concentration with another. The buyer's salary, future RSUs, career prospects and property may all remain exposed to the same city and technology cycle, he said.

Buying a primary home makes sense because rental yield and return on investment are not the sole metrics. An investment property, by contrast, faces a higher bar and must be weighed against diversified financial assets after factoring in transaction costs, taxes, maintenance, financing, vacancy rates, rental income, and liquidity.

Navlakh believes real estate may be a good investment when financial markets are turbulent, interest rates are rising, and real returns hover near zero or turn negative. From an investment standpoint, however, generating returns requires timing both the entry and exit points correctly.

"You may get the entry right, but be unable to liquidate at the right time because you are greedy and want that extra rupee; or there is a new development which seems a better investment option for buyers," he said.

A buyer should, therefore, first evaluate whether the EMI can be serviced solely from their fixed salary, without depending on future RSU appreciation, performance bonuses, or subsequent liquidity events. For a primary residence, the equation can factor in the intrinsic value of housing and stability. For an investment property, the expected return must fully offset financing costs, taxes, maintenance, vacancy risks, and the loss of liquidity.



Scan the QR code to read an extended version of this story.



POWER
POINT
PRIYA SUNDER

Respond to this column at
feedback@livemint.com

FINANCIAL RISKS YOU CAN'T SEE MAY MATTER THE MOST

During a recent visit to the Maritime Museum in Lisbon, Portugal, I stood before a life-size sculpture of Vasco da Gama. With limited navigation tools, incomplete maps and little sense of the uncharted world ahead, I wondered how he might have prepared for his voyages.

Over five centuries ago, when da Gama set sail for India, his ability to foresee danger was limited. Drawing on past explorations, he would have prepared for risks he could imagine: storms, giant waves, jagged coastlines, pirates and dwindling supplies of food and water. These risks were visible and frightening.

Yet one of the greatest dangers on da Gama's first voyage was one he did not anticipate. Midway through the journey, his sailors' limbs and gums began to swell and bleed; many grew weak and died. Only much later was this deadly affliction traced to scurvy, caused by a deficiency of vitamin C.

It made me ponder how we prepare for risks we do not yet recognise. We worry about risks we can see—the market fall, interest-rate change, currency movement or war. But risks that shape our financial lives most profoundly often build quietly over years. They hide in assumptions about income, expenses, health and lifespan until they become impossible to ignore.

Invisible risks

My neighbour's retirement is a vivid example. When he retired more than 20 years ago, he worried about market volatility, inflation, cash flows and medical or unexpected expenses. Today, his biggest concern is whether he will live much longer than planned—and whether his money will last until he is 100. With better healthcare and longer lifespans, longevity has become one of the most underestimated financial risks. It is no longer enough to retire at 60 and assume life will end around 75. Funding 15 years of retirement is very different from funding 40, especially while maintaining today's lifestyle at tomorrow's prices.

We are used to thinking of risks as market volatility. We define it narrowly by how asset prices move: equities fluctuate, so they feel risky; fixed deposit rates do not visibly fluctuate, so they feel safe. But price volatility is only one form of visible risk. The deeper, invisible financial risk is that your money may fail to meet your needs when you need it most.

An annual spend of ₹12 lakh today could rise to nearly ₹32 lakh in 20 years at 5% inflation, steadily eroding purchasing power. A 15% market fall is certainly a risk. But a 40-year-old can withstand it. He still has levers to pull: earn more, save more, reduce expenses or invest more aggressively. He has 20 years of cash inflows and decades for investments to recover and grow.

For someone in their 70s or 80s, those levers are far less flexible. The greater unseen risk is reaching a point where recovery is no longer possible. Conversely, if the 40-year-old moved his entire portfolio into "safe" assets after a market correction, he could quietly lose purchasing power over the following decades.

A safe portfolio may not support a safe life. He may need to withdraw 6% of his portfolio annually to meet expenses, while the portfolio can safely sustain only 3% without being depleted during his lifetime. The same applies to insurance. If an individual is the sole earner in her family and has ₹20 lakh of life cover against a requirement of ₹2 crore, the gap remains invisible until the day it is exposed. By then, it may be too late to correct.

Four ways to manage risk

Retain risks that support long-term goals. A measured exposure to equities can help build future wealth. Reduce concentrated risks. If too much wealth is tied to one asset class, business or property, diversification can reduce the impact of a setback. Eliminate risks where possible. Repaying a loan removes the liability and reduces pressure on future cash flows. Transfer risks that could cause severe financial damage. Life and health risks can often be transferred to an insurer through adequate cover.

Da Gama and his sailors prepared for risks they could see, but were caught unawares by an unseen danger. We can worry about market falls, interest rates or energy prices; yet successful financial plans must navigate not only visible storms, but also reefs hidden beneath the surface.

Priya Sunder, co-founder and director, PeakAlpha Investments.

'Practise asset allocation rather than choosing only equity funds'

Jash Kriplani
jash.kriplani@livemint.com
MUMBAI

With stock markets going through a difficult phase amid ongoing geopolitical tensions, rising crude oil prices and the 10-year US Treasury yield at multi-year highs, S. Naren, executive director and chief investment officer, ICICI Prudential Asset Management Co., shares his market outlook, where he sees opportunities and why his fund house is launching a contrarian fund. *Edited excerpts:*

What is your outlook for Indian markets given high US interest rates, elevated oil prices, high US 10-year Treasury yields and geopolitical tensions?

Our view has been that near-term returns could happen if oil prices decline sharply. With oil at \$107-108, coupled with high transportation costs, it remains a significant headwind for Indian markets in the near term. If oil prices

decline, markets could recover. Our broader view remains focused on asset allocation, unconstrained investing and moderate returns. This view is driven by several factors such as high US interest rates, geopolitical tensions and global equity market valuations remaining elevated.

Which sectors do you favour, and where are you concerned?

Anything connected to US AI, anywhere in the world, is not cheap and is priced for

continuous growth. If the areas face challenges to their growth assumptions, there could be significant derating. Following the recent sharp fall in insurance stocks, insurance is a sector worth considering. We have also been reasonably positive on banking, as it is one of the few sectors that remains relatively

inexpensive and has a favourable near-to-medium-term outlook. The only constraint with banking is that the investment industry already has significant exposure to the sector.

How are you viewing the

Indian IT sector in light of AI?

Initially, we did not realise that the sector was even partially disrupted. We have now concluded that AI has indeed disrupted the sector to some extent. Valuations are cheap, so it may make sense to have some exposure, but it is difficult to take an aggressive position at this point. We are not significantly negative on the sector, but we are unsure whether to take a positive view and, if so, to what extent.

How contrarian strategies differ from a value fund? Can it add differentiation for investors who own a value fund?

In a value fund, we buy stocks where implied assumptions are very low. For example, even if quick commerce underperforms, we would not be able to buy the sector simply because it is a growth sector, not a value sector. Most new-age companies would not qualify as value stocks unless we find that their implied assumptions in their valuations are very low.

When it comes to contrarian investing, we look at stocks



that have underperformed the market for over the last three to five years, occasionally over one year, and research that addressable universe to identify investment ideas.

So, there is a meaningful difference between value and contrarian investing. Contrarian investing can include value, growth or quality stocks at different points in time.

So a contrarian strategy can also include growth sectors?
Absolutely. Power equipment, for example, would have been a contrarian investment five or six years ago, although valuations were not cheap even then. Today, it would not be contrarian because the sector has outperformed.

Small-cap stocks have done well in recent months. Are valuations stretched, or could the trend continue?

I think it is primarily a function of flows which has

resulted in elevated valuations. Some companies in the small cap space have been growing well, but the current valuation differential is primarily due to the large flows into small and mid-cap mutual funds.

Are there still pockets of froth in small-caps? Should investors be cautious?

The advantage today is

Contrarian investing can include value, growth or quality stocks at different points in time

S. Naren
Executive director & CIO, ICICI Prudential AMC

allocation rather than choose only equity funds. Investors should consider categories such as balanced advantage, multi-asset and aggressive hybrid funds. However, investors are generally more comfortable choosing equity because they believe equity will always deliver returns.

Does the larger size and improved liquidity of the small-cap universe offer more comfort than five or six years ago?

We assess comfort from the perspective of margin of safety

and not market capitalisation. A high market cap does not matter as long as there is a margin of safety and we can buy the stock. Another important point is that liquidity is transient. Silver, for example, was one of the most liquid commodities at its peak in January. Therefore, liquidity and market-cap size do not particularly affect our contrarian strategy.

How should investors navigate a period of time correction and think about their portfolios?

Over the last three years, we have been advocating and telling investors to practise asset allocation rather than choose only equity funds. Investors should consider categories such as balanced advantage, multi-asset and aggressive hybrid funds. However, investors are generally more comfortable choosing equity because they believe equity will always deliver returns.

That belief is flawed as equity is a riskier asset class that can deliver high returns at times and low returns at other times. Therefore, we continue to suggest that new mutual fund investors can consider asset allocation products rather than equity products because markets can be more volatile than investors expect.

What role can SIFs play in an investor's portfolio?

Basis the specialised investment funds we have, we are not running them as aggressive funds designed to deliver very high returns. Our objective is to manage them with a more moderate-risk mindset, particularly the active asset allocator offering.

Each asset management company has freedom in how it runs SIFs, and we are grateful to Sebi (Securities and Exchange Board of India) for creating this category. We are taking a moderate-risk approach because very high-risk products are harder to scale. We want products that can be scaled and accessed by a wider audience, so we are approaching them more conservatively.



OUR VIEW



Why Gandhi's talisman should remain resonant

In 1947, he urged decision-makers to ask whether the poorest and weakest would benefit. The test didn't just survive India's pursuit of rapid economic growth, it's especially salient today

will give you a talisman," Mahatma Gandhi offered in a handwritten note shortly before India achieved freedom in 1947, "Whenever you are in doubt, or when the self becomes too much with you, apply the following test. Recall the face of the poorest and the weakest man whom you may have seen, and ask yourself if the step you contemplate is going to be of any use to him. Will he gain anything by it? Will it restore him to control over his own life and destiny? In other words, will it lead to *swaraj* for the hungry and spiritually starving millions?" Back then, 'talisman' conveyed a sort of north star for guidance, 'man' was gender-neutral and the Hindi term '*swaraj*' meant one's own liberty as much as national self-rule. The basic test that Gandhi set, however, retains both its clarity and vitality. Indeed, it ought to resonate across generations, regardless of how large India's economy grows.

For four-and-a-half decades, it was largely interpreted as a socialist filter. It may well have nudged India to adopt a 'mixed economy,' as proposed by the Bombay Plan of 1944 drafted by J.R.D. Tata, G.D. Birla and other leading industrialists. Even the country's policy remix of 1991 was broadly justified as a path out of mass deprivation. "We need to expand the scope and the area for the operation of market forces," Manmohan Singh noted in his 1991 budget speech, arguing that while price-system reforms would improve resource allocation, state intervention must focus on the needs of those on "the edges of a subsistence economy." Without wealth creation, Singh added, we would not be able to end "abject poverty, ignorance and disease." He wanted wealth harnessed in harmony with equity and justice to end poverty and serve everyone, for which he

said Gandhi's philosophy of trusteeship "should be our guiding star." Since 2014, relief for the hard-up has been a major policy theme of the Narendra Modi government too, with many welfare outlays expanded. That a larger economic pie means more money for national goals is now an axiom. The only way to tackle poverty, Modi said in his 15 August address of 2018, was "through the empowerment of poor people." This was a shift in emphasis away from entitlements, but in consonance with Gandhi's advice.

Over the past 25 years, India has seen a sharp drop in extreme poverty. Yet, as the country prospers, how badly Indian multitudes have been left behind by prosperity—at least in relative terms—looks more stark than ever. This lends Gandhi's test a renewed urgency. Signs of a 'K-shaped' economy persist long past the covid shock, with the well-off wealthier but vast numbers more or less stuck where they are. Such a split in upward mobility could spell premature market saturation, which may dampen investment in productive capacity, constrain India's overall access to capital and leave us in a 'middle-income trap.' Intimations of it, evident in some sectors already, cannot be brushed aside. If quality-of-life aspirations slump in the face of real-world hardships, the harder it will be to break above a GDP-per-head level that can fund a state apparatus designed to secure equitable health and education for all. Had this been an earnest priority right from the start, India's post-1947 emergence may have dodged the risk of that trap, arguably. But it is never too late to plug the gaps that may get in the way of our goals. This exercise must take inequities into account that economic theory tends to ignore. Even a flicker of doubt over the country's path should make us recall the poorest and weakest.

MY VIEW | FARM TRUTHS

El Niño has spelt a twin whammy for the country's rural economy

Deficient rainfall threatens not just food security but also rural incomes. India must relieve distress



HIMANSHU
is associate professor at Jawaharlar Nehru University and visiting fellow at the Centre de Sciences Humaines, New Delhi.

The monsoon season technically ended on 30 September. As expected, it was affected by the El Niño phenomenon, which typically leads to deficient rainfall in the Indian subcontinent. While final figures are yet to be released, our cumulative rainfall deficit until 29 September was 13%, marginally higher than during the 2014 drought. More than the aggregate, what matters is the geographical distribution of rainfall. This reveals a much larger deficiency of 25% in east India and the southern peninsula. The least deficit is in central India (just 3%) and then in north-west India (6%). However, there is large variation within central India, with some vulnerable areas such as Marathwada (-39%), Vidarbha (-27%) and Saurashtra (-23%) affected badly. North-west India is generally an irrigated area and thus less impacted by insufficient rains during the monsoon season. However, both eastern India and the southern peninsula include large parts that are primarily rain-fed, and weak rainfall impacts these areas proportionately more. For example, Bihar (-32%), Assam (-40%), Rayalaseema (-40%) and the interior regions of Karnataka (-31%) are likely to witness a significant impact on agricultural production. Within large states too, the rainfall deficiency is not uniform, with some parts receiving excess rain and others largely deficient. For example,

although Bihar has an overall 31% deficiency, 66% of its districts reported deficient rainfall. As for other states, 97% of Karnataka's, 64% of Maharashtra's, 82% of Tamil Nadu's and 68% of Gujarat's districts reported deficient rainfall.

It is hard to predict the precise impact on agricultural output, given India's diverse agro-climatic zones and varied cropping patterns. Any optimism over this year's sowing coverage, at 110.8 million hectares, is largely misplaced. Sowing data in India can hardly serve as an indicator of agri-health, given the preponderance of small and tiny farm holdings. The predominance of subsistence farming also means that farmers don't leave their land fallow despite deficient rains. Leaving it fallow is a luxury that few can afford. Deficient rainfall, however, does show up in cropping-pattern changes and the yields of crops sown. While yield data will only be available after the harvest, sowing numbers suggest a decline in rice acreage by 1.7 million tonnes, with a shift towards pulses and coarse cereals.

However, an inference can be drawn from past experience, particularly of recent years. In 2014, when India's rainfall deficiency was last at 12%, its impact on gross value added (GVA) was not significant, with agricultural GVA increasing by 1.2%. The index of agricul-

tural production, however, saw a sharp 4.5% decline. Rice, the primary *kharif* crop, witnessed only a 1% output decline but the overall output of cereals in that agricultural year, including *rabi* crops, was down 4.5%, along with pulses and foodgrain output, which fell 4.9%, the most after 2009-10. It wasn't rice but wheat that witnessed a big decline in 2014; its output dropped 9.7%, which pulled down overall cereal production.

This year is likely to be similar, with *rabi* crops also likely to get affected; water reservoirs have been impacted and El Niño is expected to strengthen in the coming months. By latest estimates, India's reservoir levels are lower than normal and below last year's.

Any assessment must, therefore, also account for these likely production losses. The rising cost of fertilizers has already led to decline in fertilizer use. Along with rising energy prices, Indian farmers face a double whammy of declining farm production and profitability.

The issue is no longer whether agriculture will witness lower output and lower yields, but the extent of it nationally and its regional spread. Since this year's rainfall deficiency has been greater in many rain-fed areas and other zones known for low agricultural productivity, the impact will not be limited to agricultural income compression. International agencies such as the United Nations World Food Programme have predicted a 22% global rise in the severity of acute hunger.

While India may be relatively insulated, thanks to publicly held cereal stocks, a threat to food security cannot be ignored. At the same time, supply shocks will create inflationary pressures that make it all the more difficult for the poor and vulnerable to buy staples. At a time when India's rural economy is already under stress due to rising input costs (mainly energy and fertilizers), the priority should be to protect the rural economy from the twin threats of food insecurity and income compression.

QUICK READ

This year's 13% rainfall deficiency has hurt farm output, just as a 2014 shortfall did. Uneven rains across the country left some regions worse off than others, multiplying harvest risks.

It helps that India has high food stocks but households may still find staples going out of reach.

Rising prices and weak farm earnings constitute a twin shock that policy must address.

10 YEARS AGO



JUST A THOUGHT

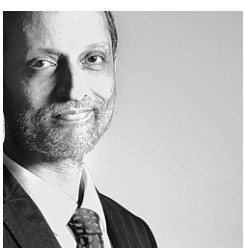
I adhere to my doctrine of trusteeship in spite of the ridicule that has been poured upon it. It is true that it is difficult to reach. So is non-violence. But we made up our minds in 1920 to negotiate that steep ascent. We have found it worth the effort.

MAHATMA GANDHI

MY VIEW | MUSING MACRO

How the Tata legacy evokes Gandhi's idea of trusteeship

AJIT RANADE



is senior fellow with Pune International Centre

Gandhi's birth anniversary this year is an appropriate occasion to examine his idea of trusteeship. The dispute involving Tata Trusts and Tata Sons has made it a live question: how can a business preserve a social purpose across generations, especially when those entrusted with it disagree?

Mahatma Gandhi accepted that talent and enterprise could create wealth and livelihoods. But what did ownership entitle a person to do with that wealth? In 1939, he wrote: "The rest of my wealth belongs to the community and must be used for the welfare of the community." By 'the rest,' he meant what remained after an honourable livelihood. That wealth would be held with owners who must act as custodians and trustees for society.

Trust is at the heart of economic life. Workers place their safety and livelihoods in the hands of an employer. Customers rely on its products and entrust it with their money and data. Communities provide land, water,

public infrastructure and the stability that helps businesses grow. None of these contributions appears fully in a company's financial figures. In addition, unborn generations inherit the effects of decisions made today. As enlightened corporate citizens, companies are expected to take these effects into account. Such companies earn an implicit licence to operate, with society's unspoken consent renewed by their conduct.

The Tata Group provides a rare example of an ownership structure built around public purpose. Philanthropic trusts hold 66% of Tata Sons, the group's holding company. The Trusts draw on wealth created by successful businesses to support education, health and other causes. Those businesses, in turn, must remain competitive and well run if the Trusts are to sustain their work. Tata philanthropy stretches back more than a century; the Trusts' commanding stake in Tata Sons gives that commitment an institutional form. This seems like a working model of Gandhi's idea.

That model is now under strain, with disagreements over leadership and a possible public listing on the stock market. There are legal questions, regulatory requirements and rights of shareholders to consider, none of which can be waved away by invoking the

Tata legacy. Equally, the value of an ownership structure dedicated to philanthropy cannot be solely measured by the prevailing market price. Hence, this dispute deserves a resolution that respects both sound business governance and the purpose for which the Trusts exist. The Tata inheritance belongs to the public in a moral sense, alongside the legal rights of its owners and the duties of its directors. This is a test of whether those rights and duties can work together with the Group's philanthropic mission.

Other arrangements are possible that reflect the spirit of Gandhi's trusteeship idea. Azim Premji committed substantial wealth from his own holding in Wipro to philanthropy while keeping philanthropic institutions apart from control of the company. The Tata Trusts combine philanthropy with decisive ownership at the apex. Both approaches can serve society.

The Tata approach requires especially clear rules on who makes busi-

ness decisions, who holds decision-makers accountable and how the Trusts fulfil their charitable duties.

Gandhi's idea also reaches inside the firm. A company may fund hospitals while also exposing workers to avoidable danger, paying small suppliers late or damaging local water sources. India's corporate social responsibility law directs qualifying firms to spend 2% of their average net profits on social causes; much useful work may result from this. But expenditure after profits are earned cannot by itself tell us how responsibly those profits were earned.

Is trusteeship too dependent on the goodwill of owners? Gandhi understood the difficulty. He called absolute trusteeship "an abstraction like Euclid's definition of a point," yet thought it worth striving for. He also recognized the need for public pressure and regulation. His economics has a clear foundation in human dignity, restraint and the welfare of others, even if it does not supply a

QUICK READ

The Tata Group offers a rare example of an ownership structure built around public purpose. Its model is now under stress amid disagreements over leadership and a public listing.

The model is akin to Gandhi's idea of business owners holding wealth as custodians for society. Resolving the Tata crisis requires a reconciliation of its corporate and philanthropic endeavours.

complete rulebook for a modern corporation.

That foundation is a good guide for decision-making. Boards can hold leaders answerable for worker safety, fair treatment of suppliers and environmental harm, alongside financial performance. Communities affected by large projects can get a real hearing. Trust deeds, board rules and succession plans can protect a public purpose if a widely respected leader is no longer around to reconcile disagreements.

Classical economics has much to say about how markets organize production and exchange. Marxian economics asks who owns the means of production and who gets the gains. Gandhi asked what obligations follow from the power to own and produce. Human dignity, restraint and the welfare of others were part of this Gandhian economics. These questions can arise under private ownership, worker ownership and state ownership alike.

Gandhi wrote: "A trustee has no heir but the public." The Tata dispute shows how difficult it can be to safeguard that principle through changing times. Its lesson for other businesses is to ask, while building wealth, whose trust makes that wealth possible—and how that trust will be preserved among those who come after us.



| MY VIEW | THE LAST WORD

MINT CURATOR

The Lindsey Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act is a travesty

Not only is it an outlier in international trade relations, it reflects much of what's wrong with today's war-ravaged world



INDIRA RAJARAMAN
is an economist.

Today, on the birth anniversary of Mahatma Gandhi, a national holiday but observed perfunctorily in terms of what he stood for, we can only rue the spectacle of a world hell-bent on war. The Graham Act of 2026 passed by both houses of Congress in the United States of America, and signed into law on 18 September, visibly places (without explicitly naming) India in the line of fire for being among the top five importers of Russian crude oil. India stands absurdly implicated thereby for being a financier of the Russian side of the war in Ukraine. Since it is an enabling legislation, the President of the United States is not obliged to act on the powers conferred by the new law to impose tariffs of upto 100% on imports into the US from erring countries, India among them.

Internationally, this is a relatively rare instance of a country finding it fit to punish third parties for having trade dealings with countries formally named and targeted in a piece of legislation despite there being no formal declaration of war against them. By implication, Russia and Iran have been designated as forever enemies of the legislating country.

During the apartheid era, many countries had trade sanctions against South Africa, but sanctions rarely involved one country punishing a third country for trade dealings with South Africa by levying source-specific tariffs on them.

The Graham Act penalizes importers of Russian natural gas differently from Russian crude oil. For natural gas, a floor of 15% of total Russian gas exports has to be crossed before an importing country qualifies for punitive tariffs on its exports to the US. If total exports of Russian natural gas can be increased by finding new buyers, present importing countries above that floor could fall below it without reducing their absolute imports. With crude oil, by contrast, only the rank order in the importer list matters. Crude oil carries no defined floor for punishability in either percentage or absolute terms.

The lenience towards natural gas clearly gives an advantage to European buyers of Russian energy, paradoxically favouring countries more vocal in their support for Ukraine. Clearly there are other objectives or biases at play. Of course, crude oil is much the biggest export earner for Russia, between double or triple what the country earns from exports of natural gas.

The Graham Act cleared the House of Representatives by a wide margin of 262-159 (14 abstentions), with wide cross-party support. Support for the bill therefore stands at an impressive 60% of the duly elected representatives from a total of 435 Congressional districts. Even though Congressional districts are drawn to give roughly



equal demographic representation across all states, it does not necessarily follow that 60% of the people of the US support the bill. Congressional representatives do not always vote according to majority opinion in their respective districts on every issue.

There is no international court of appeal. The World Trade Organization is in tatters. The Most Favoured Nation (MFN) principle has now become a sad joke. In any case, international bodies can do nothing to oppose a law passed through due process, even if it seriously overrides international treaties.

The office of the United States Trade Representative (USTR) will now be in the business of calculating a 12-month moving average of country-wise purchases of oil from Russia to identify the top five purchasers liable under the Act to punitive levies, whether the President chooses to impose a punitive levy or not. And this average will be reassessed every six months. What a come-down for the USTR, once seen as a powerful enforcer of international trade rules.

The bite of the Graham Act, if implemented, will be a function of how easily oil importers can find replacement from other sources. What seemed like a possible easing of Iranian restrictions on passage through the Strait of Hormuz, reciprocally

with US easing of the naval blockade of Iranian ports, took a jagged turn for the worse on Saturday, 26 September, because of renewed attacks on Saudi Arabia by Houthi rebels in Yemen with alleged Iranian support.

Both protagonists in the current phase of the West Asian war are at the mercy of internal disension. In the US, the forthcoming mid-term elections in the first week of November, and the impact of that on military actions before or after these polls, is completely uncertain at this point.

In Iran, a seeming national consensus in support of a diplomatically negotiated peace with the US is snaggled on a possibly dissembling faction supporting Houthi rebels in Yemen. For us in India, even if the long-term objective is to move away from oil towards sustainable sources of energy, oil is immediately needed to keep the wheels of the economy turning. The negotiation channel for a bilateral trade deal with the US remains open, and is the only hope for resolution of an impossible situation.

The wars under way have been extended by reaction and revenge. Of the many utterances of Mahatma Gandhi on peace, the one most relevant in today's world is this: "An eye for an eye only ends up making the whole world blind."

QUICK READ

The US law is a rare instance of third parties at risk of being penalized for trade dealings with specified countries despite there being no formal declaration of war against them.

Wars in Europe and West Asia have put India in a tight spot, given its dependence on oil imports. A shift to clean energy is a worthy aim but New Delhi will need to negotiate with the US for now.

The wars under way have been extended by reaction and revenge. Of the many utterances of Mahatma Gandhi on peace, the one most relevant in today's world is this: "An eye for an eye only ends up making the whole world blind."

India must fix its solar energy policies to power data centres

Capacity exists but erratic policymaking gets in the way too often



ANDY MUKHERJEE
is a Bloomberg Opinion columnist covering industrial companies and financial services in Asia.



India must do all it can to make the most of its solar-panel proliferation. **AFP**

Nobody will be surprised if in the next five to 10 years India displaces the US as the world's second-largest solar grid after China. But if its ambition is to become the world's factory, or host AI workloads for Western tech giants, power play around energy must stop. Nearly \$120 billion has gone into reducing India's reliance on fossil fuels over the past five years. The shift couldn't be more timely. Energy from Russia and West Asia is fraught with geopolitical risk; coal is abundant locally, but it contributes to deadly air pollution in cities. Yet, there is utter confusion where electric power meets erratic policymaking.

The stakes are highest in Maharashtra. Large businesses outside Mumbai tap the public grid operated by Maharashtra State Electricity Distribution Company Ltd (MSEDCL). Lately, a new category of customer has entered the fray: AI data centres.

This surge in activity is encouraging for the state utility, but there is a problem: farm use. Although MSEDCL earned a profit in 2024-25, its balance sheet remains saddled with \$88,400 crore in uncollected bills from the previous financial year, particularly from agricultural consumers.

Across India, politicians routinely supply cheap power to farmers to win votes. When state-run utilities fail to collect even those subsidized bills, they fall into endless deficits. Maharashtra wants to change this by carving out agricultural supply into a separate entity. That would leave MSEDCL as a cleaner distributor—backed by commercial and industrial customers who would no longer have to cross-subsidize the sector.

Well meaning as it may be, the cost of the reform is being extracted from private solar producers. While they have contracts to sell their output to MSEDCL, open-access rules also allow them to rent the grid from the utility to reach factories and commercial establishments directly. This worked fine until early last year, when the state electricity regulator—at MSEDCL's behest—slashed solar producers' ability to store their day-time surplus with the state utility (for a fee) to supply clients through the night.

The change isn't devoid of logic. Early in India's solar revolution, utilities provided so-called energy-banking services to guarantee producers a market. But with supply now abundant, deploying the grid as a battery is putting enormous strain on infrastructure. It makes more sense to encourage batteries right at the production site, or for the distributor to use the banking fees to build larger, more economical storage.

That much is non-controversial. But the

shift should have applied to fresh investments, which can factor battery costs into contracts. Wrecking existing projects by rendering 40% of their power generation useless makes no sense.

In Maharashtra, existing independent producers are trapped. Regulations around setting up battery storage won't be finalized before March next year, yet existing operators aren't allowed to sell excess power out-of-state. Even if they can keep storing their surplus with the grid, the proposed charges will make energy banking prohibitively expensive. Forced to cut day-time production, they risk losing high-value clients to MSEDCL.

For the utility, this will be a short-term gain. Where power is critical—like for data centres—investors may ditch Maharashtra for more welcoming states. Where will they go? In Andhra Pradesh, where the Adani Group is building a large data centre for Alphabet, the local government has decided to let these operations have their own power distribution licence. That's more investor-friendly, though the project has already attracted its share of controversy for how generous it is to corporate interests.

Disagreements over state-level regulatory orders usually land at the appellate tribunal for electricity (APTEL). But after Maharashtra chief minister Devendra Fadnavis wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi alleging a "pro-private" bias at the national body, it froze hearings involving the state utility. APTEL has now asked state officials to file an affidavit stating whether they have any faith in it at all.

The timing of this stasis is unfortunate. India needs to do all it can to get the most out of its solar boom. Yet, thanks to Maharashtra's retrospective rules, factories that had transitioned to 50% solar power may now cut back. What they will get from the utility at night is very likely going to be power generated from fossil fuels.

In India, big industrial users paid about 7 cents per kilowatt-hour last year; Chinese rivals paid 6.8 cents. Adjust for purchasing power and Indian energy is twice as pricey.

The rapid growth of solar energy may have eased India's past shortages of power, but erratic policymaking is still keeping it costlier than it needs to be—both for traditional industries and for upcoming AI data centres. **©BLOOMBERG**

| MY VIEW | PEN DRIVE

Food packaging: why we want the face turned around

PARTHA SINHA



is a senior advisory professional.

Every society must solve the same intimate problem: how to eat food prepared by a stranger. You knew the family that owned the field and the woman who ground the flour. You knew the local *halwai's* hands and his temper, the *ghee* he swore by and the *ghee* he actually used, the fly he waved off the *jalebi* with a practised wrist. Trust was never printed on the food. It surrounded it.

That trust was neither innocent nor equally assigned. Traditional Indian eating codes decided who could cook, who could serve, who could touch a water pot and who could only look at it. These codes policed people more carefully than germs. We became a country that could detect caste in a glass of water, but not lead in noodles. Yet, underneath the cruelty lay an intuition every culture shares. A chair remains a chair, but food crosses the frontier of the

body and becomes us. Anthropologists call this incorporation, and every cuisine is partly a device for managing the dread of eating the wrong thing.

Then the city grew and local food makers vanished. The grocer retreated behind a counter, the counter dissolved into an aisle and the aisle went online to slip into a phone. Into that distance stepped the brand.

Its first achievement was social substitution. Henry Heinz bottled horseradish in clear glass so buyers could see there was no turpin in it. A palm tree on a tin of Dalda persuaded a *ghee*-proud nation that hydrogenated fat was modern, thrifty and, most audaciously, pure. A round-cheeked girl on the Parle-G wrapper promised the same biscuit across the land.

The logo became the grocer in laminated form. It gave the stranger a reputation it could lose and disappointment an address. The neighbourhood *halwai* could cheat you and stay in business. A company could at least be embarrassed nationally.

But Heinz's glass was a window and Dalda's tin was a wall. At some point, branding stopped showing us the food and started showing us ourselves. Diwali arrived in Cadbury's purple foil, hostel nights in Maggi's

yellow pack and a nation's idea of *thanda* (cold) in a curved bottle that seemed drenched in sweat. Noodles ceased to be a factory product and became what mothers made late at night for children during exam season. The front of the pack became a theatre of belonging. Details printed on its back became a statutory inconvenience.

The brand's biggest offering was relief: permission to assume that somebody, somewhere, had checked its quality. We bought it gladly. Vigilance is exhausting.

The bill arrived in instalments. Worms in a purple foil in 2003 made Diwali briefly taste of doubt. Pesticides in colas seemed to give *thanda* an aftertaste. Then came traces of lead in Maggi in 2015. This monsoon, food-regulation officer Tukaram Mundhe walked into Mumbai's kitchens with a thermometer and was cheered like a cricketer. He gave the public mood a face.

QUICK READ

At one time, we knew who made our food. Then brands arrived and asked us to trust them with stuff they wanted us to eat. Now consumers want reliable health information on product packs.

Food companies must adapt. Emotion used to create trust and data confirmed it, but now data sets the terms on which emotion may operate. Dull packages full of details may be the way to go.

That mood is a new definition of trust. Back in the day, proximity made us say 'I know who made this,' while representation made us say 'I recognize the name.' Verification says 'show me.' A generation that tracks a taxi from pickup to doorstep finds it absurd that it cannot track *paneer* from milk to plate.

Old forms survive; the street *vada pav* man still runs on proximity. But a demand to see is now being made of all of them at once. Companies understand this. They print health warnings on packs in developed markets but lobby against them in India, as though the Indian liver were a harder organ.

For food businesses, a classic sequence is reversing. Emotion used to create trust and information confirmed it. Now information sets the terms on which emotion may operate. The Amul girl will keep her job, but her story must now survive contact with the kitchen. The back of the pack will outrank the

front. Lot numbers, temperature logs and test reports will gain salience. Concealment acquires a new moral meaning: what once passed for corporate discretion starts to look like guilt. Mystery may enhance a perfume brand, but it diminishes the appeal of *paneer*.

Transparency will also create its own theatre, complete with consultants and little green ticks. A QR code can lie as elegantly as a commercial and quality audits can become rituals. Society rarely graduates from myth to fact. It develops more demanding myths about what counts as fact.

Verification is costly. Temperature logs and lab reports may be pocket change for a multinational but could ruin a *halwai*. A regime built to discipline giants may end up squeezing out the small food supplier and, with him, the oldest kind of trust we have. If megacorps have noticed, few admit it.

The brand, then, must learn a humbler trade and become a witness. The strongest food companies will be those that can afford to appear boring and sell dull packages.

The face on the box is being asked to turn around. It may show us what was long kept hidden. The grocer is back. Older now, and suspicious, with a phone in hand. This time, he'll have read the pack label.

To Get All The Popular Newspapers.
Save My Contact Number 8890050582 send Message telegram ya
Whatsapp

If You Want to get these Newspapers Daily at earliest

English Newspapers»»»

Indian Express, Financial Express, The Hindu, Business Line, The Times of India, The Economic Times, Hindustan Times, ET wealth, Business Standard, First India, Mint, Greater Kashmir, Greater Jammu, The Himalayan, The Tribune, Brill Express, The Sikh Times, Avenue Mail, Western Times, Millennium Post, The Statesman, State Times, The Pioneer, Hans India, Free Press, Orissa Post, Mumbai Mirror, Mid-Day, Deccan Chronicle, Deccan Herald, Telangana Today, Financial Times, The Asian Age, The Telegraph, Oheraldo, Gulf of Times, The New York Times, The Washington Post, Los Angeles Times, USA Today, The Wall Street Journal, The Guardian, The Times

Hindi Newspapers»»»

दैनिक जागरण, राजस्थान पत्रिका, दैनिक भास्कर, दिव्यभास्कर, हिंदुस्तान, नवभारत टाइम्स, बिज़नेस स्टैंडर्ड, अमर उजाला, जनसत्ता, द पायोनीर, राष्ट्रीय सहारा, प्रभातखबर, लोकसत्ता

Others»»»

Hindi & English Editorial, Employment News, Malayalam Newspapers, Tamil, Telugu, Urdu, Gujarati

Type in Search box of Telegram @NewsTG8 And you will find a Channel named NewsTG join it and receive daily editions of all popular newspapers at the earliest

Or

you can click on this link

<https://t.me/NewsTG8>



Destinations that offer luxury on a platter



Looking for staycation options for the weekend? Some properties that offer a lot of room for indulgence and Insta-worthy images

Team Lounge

A relaxed, luxurious getaway doesn't always have to mean heading to the hills or the beach. There are several properties across the country that offer a quieter way to travel, from heritage estates and palaces to retreats surrounded by nature.

Many of these properties go beyond plush rooms and attentive service, offering a sense of place through architecture, local cuisine, history and curated experiences. They make a strong case for slowing down and exploring a region at a more leisurely pace.

We've curated a list of luxury properties that combine beautiful settings, thoughtful hospitality and a sense of quiet luxury, making them ideal for a laidback escape.

RAJASTHAN

Set along the Jodhpur-Jaisalmer highway, about 1.5 hours from Jodhpur airport, Kaner Retreat is an intimate 10-room resort spread across seven acres of the Thar desert.

Opened in 2022, the retreat offers a quieter take on Rajasthan, with experiences rooted in the landscape and local culture. Its signature Kaner Clay Experience, launched last year in October, combines a walkthrough of its Thar Desert Pottery Exhibition with a seven-course



(Clockwise from top) Kaner Retreat offers intimate breakfasts or dinners on the dunes; a Rajasthani thali; and Glenburn Penthouse captures the old-world charm of Kolkata.

lunch by chef Pankaj Sharma of Udaipur's famous fine-dining restaurant Syah.

Culinary experiences are woven into the Kaner's other activities too: an Oran, or sacred grove, walk ends with a Rajasthani *thali*, while a jeep safari culminates in an intimate dinner on the dunes.

For those who prefer their Rajasthan with a little more pulse, The Johri puts you in the heart of Jaipur's bustle.

A 19th century home, long known as Lal Haveli, Johri has been restored to offer travellers the best of both the worlds, past and present. Each of the five suites, the common areas and the restaurant have been designed by New York-based designer Naina Shah to bring together traditional and modern aesthetics. The hotel has a carefully curated collection of antique and custom furniture, textiles and art

from Rajasthan. Its restaurant focuses more on seasonal, farm-fresh produce.

There's also a cocktail bar, a daily "high-chai" afternoon tea service, option of getting Ayurvedic massages, and complimentary yoga and meditation sessions.

MADHYA PRADESH

The Oberoi Rajgarh Palace in Khajuraho is a restored 350-year-old palace set across 76 acres, with a natural lake, Sal and Palash forests and views of the Vindhya ranges.

Originally built by a maharaja of the Bundela dynasty, the palace is less than 15 minutes from the Panna National Park and Tiger Reserve and a short drive from the Khajuraho Group of Monuments. The estate has 65 rooms and suites, including private pool villas, while its dining options span royal Bundelkhandi recipes and



international cuisines.

Saj in the Forest is another option in Madhya Pradesh if you are looking for a destination that offers relaxation as well as fun. Inspired by the elements of nature, the resort, close to the Pench National Park, has three categories of rooms named after tree species: Mahua (large rooms for big groups), Palash (for small families) and Sal (suites built side by side). The walls of the resort depict the traditional Gond Art. You can also enjoy a jungle safari, a backwater safari, learn pottery, and have dinner under the stars.

DELHI

Anvaya, a six-suite luxury retreat, is a hidden gem of Delhi. Located in the Chhattarpur area, the property is like an oasis hidden near a forest while being only 20 minutes away from the heart of the Capital. Private butlers, a pool, a kitchen that serves global cuisines with a focus on seasonality—it serves luxury, comfort and everything in between.

WEST BENGAL

Less than an hour from the international airport, the nine-suite Glenburn Penthouse offers a base in the heart of Kolkata, with views of landmarks such as the Victoria Memorial and Howrah Bridge. The property, filled with antique furniture, art and vintage tableware, is close to the Maidan and Park Street, making it easy to explore the city's restaurants and cultural attractions. Its in-house menus draw on Bengali and Anglo-Indian cooking as well as Kolkata's street-food culture.

ODISHA

Set on the banks of Chilika Lake, Rambha Palace in the Ganjam district offers a glimpse of Odisha's royal heritage and hospitality. The 200-year-old pink palace retains its old-world character, with an 18th-century billiards table, French chandeliers, antique furniture and Venetian lime-plastered walls. Local craftsmanship is woven into the interiors too, from Dhokra figurines to furnishings, giving the 16-suite property a strong sense of place while offering guests a taste of life in a former royal residence. You can also sample local Odia cuisine, including a variety of seafood dishes.

Write to us at feedback@livemint.com



By the women artisans of Porgai Artisans Association.

For the weekend Of romance and Oktoberfest

A Mint guide to what's happening in and around the city

DELHI

MASTERS IN MAKING—THREADS OF CONTINUUM: REWEAVING THE FUTURE OF HERITAGE

Till 10 October

Curated by Anjchita B. Nair, the exhibition brings together 20 artists, artisans, craft-led brands and collectives engaging with textile traditions through contemporary practice. Participants include Jagrity Phukan, who explores *muga*, *eri* and mulberry silk traditions of the Brahmaputra Valley, and the Porgai Artisans Association, a collective of 80 women artisans from Tamil Nadu's Sittilingi Valley. The collective presents Lambadi embroidery, a tradition revived from near-extinction in 2000s.

11am-7pm. Alliance Française, Galerie Romain Rolland, Lodhi Estate.

PROST AT RICK'S

Till 4 October

Celebrate Munich's Oktoberfest with a Bavarian-inspired cuisine, along with a wide range of international beers. The menu includes Potato Pancake Bites with sour cream and chives, Chicken Schnitzel Bites with creamy mustard aioli, Currywurst with curried tomato sauce and crispy fries, and Apfelstrudel with vanilla ice cream.

5pm-12.45am. Rick's, Taj Mahal, Man Singh Road.



Oktoberfest fest at Delhi's Taj.

BENGALURU

BAREFOOT IN THE PARK

3 October

Directed by Sridhar Ramanathan and Shubham Srivastava, this two-hour play is based on Neil Simon's much-loved Broadway classic. It follows the early days of a marriage, turning the adjustments and disagreements into an entertaining mix of romance and chaos.

3pm/6.30pm. Bangalore International Centre, 4th Main Rd, 2 Stage, Domlur. For details, visit bookmyshow.com

MUMBAI

KAB SE BAITHE: DREAM NOTE LIVE

2 October

Enjoy an evening of Hindi songs with pop-rock influences by Jaipur-based indie-pop duo Dream Note, comprising singer-songwriter Gaurav Tiwari and guitarist and music producer Tareh Agarwal.

8pm. The Studio Theatre, Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre, Bandra. For details, visit www.nmacc.com

Inside the global market for elite \$30,000 sheepdogs

Britain's border collies are attracting buyers who see them as indispensable workers, not pampered pets

Bloomberg

Del set off at a tear, turning on a dime as he corralled three sheep around the field. His white socks and the flash of white across his nose were nothing but a blur.

Nearby, his trainer stood with a whistle between his pursed lips. The 5-year-old border collie stopped, sank low to the ground and waited. On cue, he took off again. This ballet between sheepdog and flock continued for a few minutes in front of the roughly 200 people who'd gathered on a mild July morning in Skipton, a town near Leeds in northern England. Several dozen others watched via webcam. Then the bidding began. Over the past three decades, Skipton's Craven Cattle Mart (CCM) has grown into an international hub for some of the world's best working sheepdogs. Some of them end up in the US and Europe, even as far as Japan. Dogs sold here have fetched as much as \$30,000, putting them among the most

expensive sheepdogs ever sold. Among the pickup trucks and farm vehicles in the parking lot were high-end SUVs adorned with personalized license plates. Most of those in the crowd appeared to be locals. But watching from the edge of the field was Toru Takei, who, among the work boots and fleece vests, stood out in his Los Angeles Dodgers cap and sneakers.

Takei had read about the Skipton sheepdog sales from his home in Japan, where he farms 23 sheep as a hobby and has a keen interest in herding competitions known as sheepdog trials, a sport that's taking off abroad. He already has two—one from the Netherlands and another from Wales, where he had plans to visit during his trip to the UK.

"There are less dogs in Japan. I have no selection," Takei says. He hopes to buy another one day, this time from Skipton, but today, he's just here to watch. Border collies have been bred for generations to herd sheep, their natural instincts moulded further by trainers and farmers to respond to voice commands or a whistle. They're sold as puppies or fully trained, or "broken."

Unsung to outsiders, sheepdogs are vitally important to operations of commercial farms, and adored by devout trialists, some of whom travel the world competing. On 20 September, thousands of spectators and competitors from 34 coun-



tries converged on Scotland for "the biggest World Trial ever," according to the president of the International Sheep Dog Society.

Christine Ryder, who manages about a thousand sheep and a herd of cows with her husband at their farm in nearby Blubberhouses, tells the signs of a good worker: "Their ears are up, and they're watching everything. They're ready to go. If a sheep turns and starts coming towards it, if they turn and run away, well, that's no good to anybody."

Skipton has long been synonymous

with sheep farming. References to a "sheep town" on this site date to as early as the 11th century. It sits at the southern edge of the Yorkshire Dales National Park, with valleys and moors carved into fields by drystone walls stretching for miles to the north. A charter granted by King John in 1204 first allowed Skipton to start a market selling sheep and wool. The town's importance as a market hub grew when the Leeds & Liverpool Canal was built during the Industrial Revolution more than 500 years later. The first official Skipton auction took place in 1886 not far

from the town centre, on the site of what's now a grocery store.

Today, CCM sits just outside of town. It's become a place farmers go not only to buy and sell but also to socialize. The sheepdog sales, with their record-setting prices and international clientele, now attract many who simply come out to watch. A good sheepdog is often more useful than a human employee, able to cover huge distances quickly. It's part of why some buyers will travel so far to buy one. Some dogs can also work cattle. And while drones and robots have been touted for more than a decade as potential replacements for sheepdogs, sheep grow used to and start to ignore drones.

CCM started sheepdog sales in 1996. At that time there were only a couple of other places selling dogs in Britain. In those early days, many sold at auction were "rejects," says Eaton, the auctioneer, meaning surplus to a farm's needs rather than quality. But shepherds and trialists who trained dogs saw an opportunity to start intentionally breeding, finding and training the sheepdogs, specifically for the auctions. "It opened up almost a new cottage industry," Eaton says. Interest grew in lockstep with the quality of the dogs on offer, particularly among sheepdog trialists who were competing at an international level for their countries.

Over the next two decades, Skipton

grew into a premier sheepdog trading destination, and the dogs themselves became headline-making luxury investments.

These days, CCM runs several sheepdog sales a year. Some are entirely online, such as the one on 23 September, where trainers uploaded recorded videos of their dogs. Over the past 12 months, multiple dogs sold online have made five figures, heading to northern England, Ireland and the south of France. They can have resale value too: A 5-year-old dog previously bought by a now-retired shepherd was sold to an anonymous buyer in Germany for £4,200.

American Samantha Furman got her first border collie 30 years ago. At the time, she had planned to become an accountant. But she started doing lessons with a highly regarded handler, for whom she ended up working for several years. Then she got a few sheep of her own to train her dogs with and became part of the then-fledgling US sheepdog trial circuit, which has since boomed in popularity. Farming followed.

"Somewhere in there, I really just got pretty passionate about the sheep and wanted to do the best I could," says Furman, who lives appropriately enough in Farmville, Virginia. She now has a flock of 600.

Write to us at feedback@livemint.com